The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra "The Questions of the Divine Son Susthitamati"

Āryasusthitamatidevaputraparipṛcchānāmamahāyānasūtra · Toh 80 · Derge Kangyur
འཕགས་པ་ལྷའི་བུ་བློ་གྲོས་རབ་གནས་ཀྱིས་ཞུས་པ་ཞེས་བྱ་བ་ཐེག་པ་ཆེན་པོའི་མདོ།

The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra called The Questions of the Divine Son Susthitamati, known in Sanskrit as the Āryasusthitamatidevaputraparipṛcchā and in Tibetan as Phags pa lha'i bu blo gros rab gnas kyis zhus pa, is a Mahāyāna discourse set on Vulture Peak near Rājagṛha, where the Buddha is joined by a vast assembly of renowned arhats and bodhisattvas, among them Mañjuśrī, Maitreya, and Avalokiteśvara. Framed as an exchange prompted by the questions of the young god Susthitamati, the sutra explores the bodhisattva path and the emptiness of all phenomena. It gives Mañjuśrī a prominent role in showing how the realization that actions, agents, and results lack inherent existence can free practitioners from guilt and remorse over past deeds. It is Toh 80 in the Kangyur, where it belongs to the Heap of Jewels, or Ratnakūṭa, collection of sutras.

The Noble Explanation Requested by the Divine Son Susthitamati. The first section.

In the language of India: ārya susthitamati deva putra paripṛcchā nāma mahā yāna sūtra. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra Called "The Questions of the Divine Son Susthitamati."

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One (the Buddha) was staying in Rājagṛha, on Vulture Peak, together with a great Saṅgha of sixty-two thousand monks, all of them renowned arhats. He was also with forty-two thousand bodhisattvas, Mañjuśrī, Siṃhaketu, and others. Among them were the bodhisattva great beings Maitreya, Avalokiteśvara, Mahāsthāmaprāpta, Pratibhānakūṭa, Dhāraṇīśvararāja, Merukūṭa, Merudhvaja, Utterly Unshakable, Mind Intent on the Goal, Well-Considered Mind, Heroic Mind, Cittamati, Good Mind, Maṇikūṭa, King Who Crushes Mountains, Ratnapāṇi, Jewel Mind, Ratnamudrāhasta, Nityotkṣiptahasta, Ever Outstretched Hand, Nityodyukta, Liberator of Beings, Devoted to Diligence, Abiding in Doing as He Says, Noble Aspiration, Pradīpapāṇi, Even Mind, Abandoner of the Lower Realms, Dispeller of All the Darkness of Sorrow, Anikṣiptadhura, Sūryagarbha, Vajra Subduer, Anantavikrāmin, Amitavikrāmin, Subduer with Unmoving Stance,

Gaganagañja, Excellent Intelligence, Viśeṣamati, Vardhamānamati, Accomplisher of Beings, Dharaṇīṃdhara, Candraprabha, Candraketu, Prabhāketu, Prabhāśrī, Subduer by Attaining Light, Roar Proclaimed by Lionlike Subduing, Asaṅgapratibhāna, Laughing Eloquence, Heroic Eloquence, Vikrāmin, Light That Dims the Rays of Sun and Moon, Without Reference Point, Anupamamati, Lord of Constant Laughter and Joy, Jewel, Sarvanīvaraṇaviṣkambhin, Armor That Transforms Women, Brilliant Radiance, Vairocana, Agnidatta, Supreme King of Hosts, and the bodhisattva great being Profound Voice. With these and others, forty-two thousand bodhisattva great beings in all, he was staying.

He was also together with the Four Great Kings; Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods; Brahmā, lord of the Sahā world; and besides these, some sixty thousand divine sons. He was also together with the divine son Susthitamati, the divine son Susīma, the divine son Maheśvara, the divine son Sumati, and others, seventy-three thousand divine sons in all, every one of them having truly entered the bodhisattva vehicle. He was also together with Rāhu, lord of the asuras, Meru, lord of the asuras, and others, twenty thousand lords of the asuras in all, every one of them having truly entered the bodhisattva vehicle. He was also together with Anavatapta, king of the nāgas, Candra, king of the nāgas, Takṣaka, king of the nāgas, and others, sixty thousand nāga kings in all, every one of them having truly entered the bodhisattva vehicle. And besides these he was together with many hundreds of thousands of gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, and mahoragas, and with monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen.

Then the Blessed One, encircled and faced by an assembly of many hundreds of thousands, taught the Dharma.

At that time the youthful Mañjuśrī was staying in his own dwelling, alone and secluded, engaged in inward composure and free of afflictions, and he entered into the meditative absorption called Without Mind and Free from Mind. Then the youthful Mañjuśrī arose from that absorption, mindful and vigilant. The very moment the youthful Mañjuśrī arose, countless buddha fields in the ten directions shook in six ways.

Then, having arisen from that absorption, the youthful Mañjuśrī had this kind of mental engagement, a conceptual perception, and he thought:

"Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas appear in the world only very rarely. Just as the udumbara flower appears in the world only very rarely,

so too the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly awakened buddhas, who, in order to bring the suffering of birth to an end, teach a Dharma that is peaceful and clear, unfathomable by examination, beyond the reach of reasoning, profound, and hard to understand, appear in the world only very rarely. If no buddha appears, there is no hearing of the Dharma. If there is no hearing of the Dharma, there is no ending of the suffering of sentient beings. Therefore I shall go into the presence of the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly awakened Buddha, and ask him questions: by what means the roots of virtue of sentient beings may be fully accomplished; how persons of the bodhisattva vehicle may become free of hesitation and doubt regarding the inconceivable qualities of the Buddha; and how they may perfect the awakening of a buddha. The sentient beings of this Sahā world system are all of great attachment, great aversion, and great delusion; they are devoid of bright qualities and possessed of unwholesome qualities; they are dull, foolish, and irreverent; they are bereft of the Buddha, bereft of the Dharma, and bereft of the Saṅgha. Therefore I shall ask the kind of questions by which these beings, having heard the Dharma, may by all means have the eye of wisdom purified."

Then Mañjuśrī the Youthful also thought, "I shall gather the bodhisattvas of the ten directions who will listen to the Dharma from the Tathāgata, and also the many hundreds of thousands who will directly realize, in their own persons, this profound acceptance."

Then Mañjuśrī the Youthful entered into the meditative absorption called the Immaculate Array of Universal Illumination. The very moment Mañjuśrī the Youthful had entered into the absorption of the Immaculate Array of Universal Illumination, at that instant buddha fields in the east and in all ten directions, as many as the sands of the river Ganges, were pervaded by a great light, pleasing, soft, completely pure, luminous, stainless and utterly purified, and by a great illumination. By that light and that illumination, all that exists in the worlds of the ten directions, the darkness and deep gloom of the spaces between the worlds, the mountain peaks, the trees, the mountains, the Cakravāḍa ranges, Mucilinda and Great Mucilinda, the snow mountains, Sumeru and the great Meru, all of these were lit up by the great illumination.

Then the buddhas, the blessed ones, as many as the sands of the river Ganges, who dwell, live and abide in the worlds of the ten directions, were asked by their own attendants: "Blessed One, this light so pleasing to the mind, never seen or heard of before, this great illumination of luminosity appearing in the world like this: Blessed One, what is its cause? What is its

condition? Blessed One, through this light our minds have become clear and our bodies are filled with great ease, and the attachment, aversion and delusion of beings do not arise at all. Blessed One, by whose power has such a light been sent forth? By whose blessing?"

When they had asked this, those buddhas, the blessed ones, said nothing at all to their attendants. Through the power of the Buddha, every sound in the worlds of the ten directions fell silent: the sounds of gods, the sounds of nāgas, the sounds of yakṣas, the sounds of asuras, the sounds of garuḍas, the sounds of gandharvas, the sounds of kiṃnaras, the sounds of mahoragas, the sounds of humans, the sounds of nonhumans, the sounds of birds, and the sounds of wild animals. Every sound of wind, of masses of water, of the surging of the great ocean, of music and of song likewise fell silent. Nothing made any sound; everything became peaceful and utterly still.

Again the attendants of those buddhas, the blessed ones, asked a second and a third time: "For the benefit of many people, for the happiness of many people, for the welfare, benefit and happiness of the great multitude of gods and humans, please explain by whose power it is that the Blessed One has sent forth such a light, by which all these buddha fields have been illuminated."

Then all those buddhas, the blessed ones, of the buddha fields of the ten directions, as many as the sands of the river Ganges, gathered the voices of the speech of all the buddhas into a single tone and spoke forth the activity of their speech. Just as one tathāgata spoke, so did all the others likewise; and with that activity of speech gathered into a single tone, they addressed their attendants. The speech uttered by those buddhas, the blessed ones, completely filled all the buddha fields. Many hundreds of thousands of cymbals of gods and humans gave forth sound, and musical instruments resounded without being played. From the sounds of that music arose sounds of impermanence, of suffering and of selflessness; the sound of emptiness, the sound of signlessness, the sound of wishlessness, the sound of freedom from attachment, the sound of liberation, the sound of the dharma realm (dharmadhātu), the sound of suchness, the sound of the true limit of reality, the sound of generosity, the sound of moral discipline, the sound of patience, the sound of diligence, the sound of meditative concentration, the sound of wisdom, the sound of gentleness, the sound of the means of benefiting others, the sounds of loving-kindness, compassion, joy and equanimity, and the sounds of many hundreds of thousands of gateways of Dharma in accord with

these.

Through these sounds that arose, countless, incalculable hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of sentient beings became irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, from the state of a śrāvaka, from the state of a pratyekabuddha, from the state of Śakra (Indra), from the state of Brahmā, and from the attainment of the reign of a universal monarch.

Then those buddhas, the blessed ones, spoke to their attendants as follows: "Sons of noble family, what good will it do you to ask about such a matter? Let it be! This light has been purified through inconceivably vast roots of virtue, through inconceivably vast accumulations of generosity, and through accumulations of moral discipline, patience, diligence, meditative concentration and wisdom. It is not the work of any śrāvaka or pratyekabuddha. Should the Tathāgata proclaim the praises of this light, the whole world with its gods would be bewildered by it. This light, permeated throughout by all loving-kindness, compassion, joy and equanimity, brings complete satisfaction. Were one to proclaim the praises of this light for an eon, or for more than an eon, it would not be easy to reach the end of its praises. Nevertheless, sons of noble family, listen well and keep it firmly in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

The attendants of those buddhas, the blessed ones, asked a second and a third time as follows:

"For the benefit of many people, for the happiness of many people, and to bring the roots of virtue of the bodhisattvas to completion, may the Blessed One please explain."

When they had made this request, those buddhas, the blessed ones, spoke to their own attendants: "Sons of good family, there is a world called the Sahā world. There dwells the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha called Śākyamuni, perfect in knowledge and conduct, the Sugata, knower of the world, unsurpassed guide of beings to be tamed, teacher of gods and humans, the Buddha, the Blessed One. He lives and abides there, in a world marked by the five degenerations. In the buddhafield of such beings, beings tormented by attachment, aversion and delusion, irreverent, of dull faculties, devoid of shame and of conscience, engaged in afflicted actions, he has fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening, and he teaches the Dharma.

"Sons of good family, in the Sahā world, the buddhafield of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Śākyamuni, there is a bodhisattva called the youthful Mañjuśrī. He is of great power, great knowledge and great diligence. He instructs the bodhisattvas, inspires the bodhisattvas to take up the path, uplifts the bodhisattvas and gladdens the bodhisattvas. He serves as a father to the bodhisattvas and serves as a mother to the bodhisattvas. He is skilled in the knowledge that discerns the basis of all phenomena, has attained the unattached perfection of wisdom, possesses unimpeded eloquence, has attained the dhāraṇīs, and is endowed with the inconceivable qualities of a bodhisattva. In order to bring to completion the roots of virtue of beings, and to perfect the inconceivable qualities of a buddha in the individuals of the Bodhisattva Vehicle, he has asked questions about the Dharma of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Śākyamuni.

"Sons of good family, that bodhisattva, the youthful Mañjuśrī, has sent forth this light in order to gather from the ten directions the countless bodhisattvas who will listen to that teaching of the Dharma and assemble for it. Sons of good family, that is the cause and that is the condition of this great illumination that has appeared in the world."

When they had said this, the attendants of those buddhas, the blessed ones, said, "Blessed One, abiding in what meditative absorption does that bodhisattva, the youthful Mañjuśrī, send forth such light as this?"

They replied, "It is the meditative absorption called the Stainless Array of Universal Illumination. Abiding in that meditative absorption, the bodhisattva, the youthful Mañjuśrī, sends forth such light as this."

They said, "Blessed One, the buddhas, the blessed ones, do not send forth light like this, so clear, so pure, so gladdening and delighting to body and mind."

They replied, "Sons of good family, it is because the Dharma discourse that gathers bodhisattvas and urges bodhisattvas on is not always taught."

Then, in the immeasurable, countless, inconceivable buddhafields of the ten directions, as many as the grains of sand in ten million Ganges rivers, from each and every buddhafield immeasurable, countless, inconceivable hundreds of thousands of niyutas of koṭis of bodhisattvas went to where those buddhas, the blessed ones, were. Having arrived, they bowed their heads at the feet of those buddhas, the blessed ones, and said to them, "Blessed One, this light,

possessing many qualities, never before seen or heard, this illumination, this blaze: where does it come from, and whose light is it?"

When they had asked this, those buddhas, the blessed ones, said to those bodhisattvas, "Sons of good family, there is a world called the Sahā world. There dwells the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha called Śākyamuni. He lives and abides there, and he teaches the Dharma. There dwells a bodhisattva called the youthful Mañjuśrī, and in order to gather the bodhisattvas of the ten directions he has sent forth this blazing light."

When they had said this, those bodhisattvas said to those buddhas, the blessed ones, "Blessed One, we will go to that Sahā world in order to see the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Śākyamuni, to pay homage to him, to serve him, to ask him questions and to inquire of him, and also to see the bodhisattva, the youthful Mañjuśrī, and the other bodhisattvas there."

They replied, "Sons of good family, if you know that the time has come, go."

Then, at that very moment, in an instant, a moment, a second, in just the time it takes a strong man to stretch out his bent arm or to bend his outstretched arm, immeasurable, countless, inconceivable hundreds of thousands of niyutas of koṭis of bodhisattvas from the ten directions vanished from their own buddhafields and arrived here in this Sahā world. Some of those bodhisattvas let fall rains of flowers as they came to where the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Śākyamuni was.

Some, letting fall showers of powders, ointments, garlands and incense, and showers of many different kinds of flowers, utpala, padma, kumuda, white lotuses, campaka, atimuktaka, kyanar, dhanuṣkārī, sumanā flowers, vārṣika and great vārṣika, māndārava and great māndārava, pāruṣaka and great pāruṣaka, moon-colored flowers, great moon-colored flowers, supremely beautiful moon-colored flowers and the like, showers of incense, showers of garlands and showers of powders, came to where the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Śākyamuni was.

Some bodhisattvas, playing many hundreds of thousands of cymbals, came to where the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Śākyamuni was.

Some bodhisattvas came with voices praising the Tathāgata, each single voice making itself heard throughout the world systems of a great trichiliocosm. With such manifold displays they came to where the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Śākyamuni was.

The very moment those bodhisattvas arrived in this Sahā world, at that very instant, through the power of those bodhisattvas, all the sentient beings in this great trichiliocosm world system, whatever beings there were in the hells, in the animal realm and in the world of Yama, the lord of death, were completely soothed. No sentient being was harmed by attachment, nor by aversion, nor by delusion, nor by pride, nor by jealousy, nor by miserliness, nor by concealment, nor by wrath, nor by torment. All sentient beings came to possess a mind of loving-kindness and a mind of supreme joy.

Then those bodhisattvas, immeasurable, countless and inconceivable, numbering hundreds of thousands of trillions of ten-millions of myriads, went to where the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Śākyamuni was. Having arrived, they bowed their heads at the feet of the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Śākyamuni, and circumambulated the Blessed One three times. Then, in the sky above, they made their bodies invisible, entered into the meditative absorption called the Dissolution of All Bodies, and sat cross-legged upon the hearts of lotuses that had arisen from their own aspirations, lotuses of many colors, each with many hundreds of thousands of petals.

Then the elder Mahākāśyapa saw that great, wondrous and marvelous miracle of the Dharma, those showers of flowers, showers of incense and showers of powders, those many hundreds of thousands of cymbals resounding, and that great radiance. He also saw this world system of four great continents covered knee-deep in flowers. And he also saw that the bodies of all that great assembly, the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kiṃnaras, mahoragas, humans and non-humans, monks, nuns, laymen and laywomen, appeared to be the color of gold.

Then the elder Mahākāśyapa rose from his seat, draped his robe over one shoulder, and placed his right knee on the ground. Bowing with palms joined toward the Blessed One, he praised the Blessed One with these verses:

Your utterly stainless face grants supreme joy and bliss;
Best of humans, with ten powers, you have amassed hundreds of qualities;
Inconceivable, immeasurable, you dispel the darkness of doubt.

Among all who roam the earth, the sky and the realms of the gods, there is none equal to you.
For hundreds of trillions of eons you practiced well both giving and discipline.
Sugata, your moral discipline has no equal; there is none like it anywhere.
Mighty in the strength of patience, endowed with the power of the ten powers,
Possessor of good qualities, smiling one, please dispel my doubts.

Seeing the suffering of sentient beings, though you practiced for hundreds of eons,
You had no weariness and did not give up, and you found immeasurable joy.
Sons and daughters, queens and kingdom, your eyes and many other things you gave away.
You of joyful gaze, who gave away everything, please dispel my doubts.

In the past you gave horses and elephants, chariots and troops of soldiers.
Delighting in giving, you gave away your head and your garments hundreds of trillions of times.
The Sage gave food and drink, and likewise palaces and treasuries as well.
Sugata, ever delighting in generosity and giving, I ask of you.

Firmly relying on the teachings of emptiness and contemplating them well in your mind,
Stainless one, though your body was cut to pieces, you had no suffering or agitation.
When asked to speak, you strove in the power of proclaiming patience.
Possessor of good qualities, stainless one, I wish to ask you a question.

Seeing beings deeply stirred by desire and aversion, deluded and entangled,
Sentient beings who strive in the notion of a self, sunk in suffering,
You gave rise to compassion and acted in this existence for hundreds of eons.
Hero who teaches the supreme path, may you be my refuge!

Sugata, doer of good, you are unhindered among beings.
By practicing your conduct well, you attained the bases of miraculous power and wisdom.
Dismantling the notions of self and of sentient being, you strive in the Dharma of emptiness.
Utterly stainless one, who contemplate and meditate, remove my doubts.

In the past you relied on peerless generosity, moral discipline, patience, diligence,
Meditative concentration, wisdom, compassion and loving-kindness.

Your good qualities are inconceivable, like the clouds and the ocean.
Excellent source, firmly abiding, may you be my refuge!

Stainless one, you cut your body into piece after piece
And weighed it on a scale, and leaving no scrap or remnant behind,
You gave away your entire body and did not abandon a single young pigeon.
Stainless maker of light, compassionate one, please cut off my doubts.

Even if the mountain where the hosts of gods dwell should shake and the sky should fall,
Even if the ocean, abode of the hosts of asuras, should run dry,
Even if the sun and moon that dwell and move in the sky should fall suddenly to the earth,
Victor who acts uprightly, you would never speak a false word.

Then the elder Mahākāśyapa, having praised the Blessed One with these verses, said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, a great illumination has appeared in the world, and there are such vast signs, wondrous and marvelous. What is the cause of this? What is the condition?"

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Mahākāśyapa, "Kāśyapa, what is it to you to ask such a question? Leave it! This is not within the reach of any śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas. If the Tathāgata were to explain this matter, this world with its gods would become bewildered and confused."

He said, "Blessed One, may the Tathāgata please explain it, for the benefit of many people and for the happiness of many people."

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the venerable Mahākāśyapa, "Therefore, Kāśyapa, listen well and keep it firmly in mind, and I shall explain."

The elder Mahākāśyapa said, "Excellent, Blessed One," and listened as the Blessed One directed. The Blessed One then said, "Kāśyapa, here the youthful Mañjuśrī has entered into the meditative absorption called Stainless Array of Universal Illumination. By its power he illuminated with light buddha fields in the ten directions as numerous as the grains of sand in ten million Ganges rivers. That light roused immeasurable, countless, inconceivable hundreds of thousands of trillions of tens of millions of quadrillions of bodhisattvas in the ten directions. They came to this Sahā world, and just now they bowed their heads at my feet, circumambulated me three times, and took their seats on

lotuses in the sky above, at the height of seven palm trees."

Then the venerable Mahākāśyapa said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, is it by the power of those bodhisattvas that such rains of flowers as these are falling, that rains of incense and rains of powder are falling as well, and that many hundreds of thousands of cymbals are sounding without being played?"

The Blessed One said, "Kāśyapa, it is so. It is by the power of those bodhisattvas that such rains of flowers as these are falling, that rains of incense and rains of powder are falling as well, and that many hundreds of thousands of cymbals are sounding without being played."

He said, "Blessed One, there are no bodhisattvas here at all."

The Blessed One said, "Kāśyapa, they cannot be seen by śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Why is that? Because, Kāśyapa, śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas do not abide in the great compassion, the great loving-kindness, the wish to benefit and the conduct in which bodhisattvas abide, nor in the generosity, moral discipline, patience, diligence, meditative concentration and wisdom in which bodhisattvas abide; nor do they practice the superior intention that bodhisattvas practice. Kāśyapa, those bodhisattvas have entered into the meditative absorption called Dissolution of All Bodies, and therefore they cannot be seen by śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas; they are seen by the tathāgatas alone. Kāśyapa, since those sons of good family are not seen for the present even by bodhisattvas who abide on the grounds or by bodhisattvas newly entered into the vehicle, what need is there to speak of their being seen by śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas? That is impossible."

When he had said this, the venerable Mahākāśyapa said to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, by possessing how many qualities, what kind of conduct, and what sort of roots of virtue does a bodhisattva attain the bodhisattva absorption of the destruction of all bodies?"

The Blessed One said, "Kāśyapa, a bodhisattva who possesses ten qualities attains the bodhisattva absorption of the destruction of all bodies. What are the ten? They are: rightly entering into superior intention; never forsaking any sentient being; bringing great compassion to perfection; destroying all signs; focusing intently on all the qualities of a buddha while having no conceit about them; not focusing intently on the stages of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, and seeking a wisdom beyond them; giving away all one's possessions, for since one gives away even body and life, what need is there

to mention other things; gathering immeasurable accumulations while having no conceit on account of those accumulations; bringing immeasurable generosity, moral discipline, patience, diligence, meditative concentration and wisdom to perfection while not conceptualizing those perfections; and thinking, 'Having established all sentient beings in the qualities of a buddha, only afterward shall I go to the foot of the tree of awakening,' while yet not apprehending either sentient beings or awakening. Kāśyapa, a bodhisattva who possesses these ten qualities attains the bodhisattva absorption of the destruction of all bodies."

When he had said this, the elder Mahākāśyapa said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, it is wonderful how far the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, speaks such excellent words, of which those of the śrāvaka vehicle and those of the pratyekabuddha vehicle have never conceived even a single thought. Were I to think of setting all sentient beings even in the qualities of arhatship, what need would there be to speak of the qualities of a buddha?"

The Blessed One said, "Kāśyapa, that is why śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are unable to enter the absorption of the destruction of all bodies. Since they do not even know the name of that absorption, what need is there to mention entering it? That is impossible."

When he had said this, the elder Mahākāśyapa said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, I wish to see those bodhisattvas. And why? Because, Blessed One, such holy beings are hard to see."

The Blessed One said, "Kāśyapa, wait for a while, until the youthful Mañjuśrī has passed by. Then those bodhisattvas will arise from that absorption, and after that you will see them. Kāśyapa, even so, since you yourself have attained the states of absorption, find out in what posture those bodhisattvas abide."

Then the elder Mahākāśyapa, heeding the Blessed One's word, and in order to see in what posture those bodhisattvas abide, at that time, through the power of the Buddha and by rousing his own strength, entered twenty thousand absorptions and arose from them, yet he did not see them. He did not know the coming or the going of those bodhisattvas, nor did he know their dwelling or their abode. Whatever they did and whatever they displayed, he neither knew nor saw at all, in any way whatsoever.

Then the elder Mahākāśyapa said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, it is wonderful that, even though I entered twenty thousand absorptions, I did not

see those bodhisattvas. Sugata, it is truly wonderful. Blessed One, if it is so even with these bodhisattvas who have not yet attained omniscience, through their accomplishing such a peaceful absorption, what need is there to speak of those bodhisattvas who have attained the wisdom of omniscience? Blessed One, what son or daughter of good family would not generate the mind set on unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening? Blessed One, if a bodhisattva dons the armor for the sake of this very absorption of the destruction of all bodies, that is donning the armor well. Therefore this absorption should never be given up, even later."

The Blessed One said, "Kāśyapa, so it is. It is just as you have said. This is not within reach even of all the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, so what need is there to speak of other beings?"

Then the elder Śāriputra thought, "I have been declared by the Tathāgata to be the foremost of those who possess wisdom. I shall examine in what posture those bodhisattvas abide." Then, in order to see those bodhisattvas, the elder Śāriputra entered thirty thousand absorptions and arose from them, yet he was unable to know even their signs.

Then the elder Subhūti thought, "I shall look upon those bodhisattvas." Then, in order to see those bodhisattvas, the elder Subhūti, through the power of the Buddha and by rousing his own strength, entered forty thousand absorptions and arose from them, yet he did not know their coming or their going. He did not see them standing, did not see them walking, did not see them sitting, and did not see them lying down; he was unable to see them.

Then the elder Subhūti touched the Blessed One's two feet and said this to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, the Tathāgata has declared me foremost among those who dwell free of afflictions. Since I have attained the peaceful meditative absorptions, Blessed One, suppose this world-system of four great continents became the hollow of a single great drum, and another world-system of four great continents also became the hollow of a single great drum. Suppose some person were born there, took up a drumstick the size of Mount Meru, came before me while I was absorbed in meditative absorption, and, doing no other work at all, beat those two great drums without interruption for an eon. Even so, Blessed One, because I dwell free of afflictions, having practiced in this way and attained the peaceful meditative absorptions, the sounds of those two great drums, though they went on for more than an eon, would not reach me

even as a bare ear-consciousness. What need is there, then, to speak of their rousing me from that meditative absorption? That is impossible. Yet, Blessed One, though I possess such dwelling free of afflictions and such wisdom, and though I entered into and arose from forty thousand meditative absorptions in order to see those bodhisattvas, I did not see them, nor do I know where they abide.

"Blessed One, if bodhisattvas, in seeking such wisdom, were to burn in the great hells of sentient beings for as many eons as there are grains of sand in the river Ganges for the sake of each single sentient being, they would undertake it with enthusiasm. Blessed One, bodhisattvas would not give up such inconceivable wisdom.

"Blessed One, had my mind not been liberated from the defilements without clinging, I would wander in saṃsāra to the very end of the future, and I would not abandon such a Great Vehicle as this."

Then the Blessed One gave his approval to the Elder Subhūti, saying, "Excellent!" and continued: "Subhūti, it is excellent, excellent, that you have spoken those words with such superior intention. Subhūti, had you not passed into complete nirvāṇa with these very aggregates, then through this root of virtue you would have entered upon the kingship of a universal monarch as many times as there are grains of sand in the river Ganges, and you would also have fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

"Subhūti, are the sentient beings in the great trichiliocosm many?"

He replied, "They are many, Blessed One. They are many, Sugata."

The Blessed One said, "Subhūti, for the sake of examining this, suppose all those sentient beings came to possess knowledge like that of the monk Subhūti, of Śāriputra and of Mahākāśyapa. Subhūti, even if such great śrāvakas as these were to search for many hundreds of thousands of koṭis of niyutas of eons in order to see those bodhisattvas, they would not be able to see them. Why is that? Subhūti, it is because śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas do not practice the dharmas that bodhisattvas practice. Subhūti, that is not the domain of any śrāvaka or pratyekabuddha."

While this teaching was being given, eighty-four thousand living beings among the multitudes of gods and humans generated the mind set on unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī, sitting in that very place, thought, "Since these many hundreds of thousands of koṭis of niyutas of bodhisattvas have assembled, I too should gather many hundreds of thousands of gods."

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī at that time performed such a miraculous display that the following came about. He emanated eighty-four hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas of lotuses the size of chariot wheels, with petals of gold, stems of silver, cores of the jewel called śrīgarbha, and anthers made of beryl. On those lotuses he also emanated bodily forms of bodhisattvas, golden in color, endowed with the thirty-two marks of a great being, glorious, of beautiful color, splendid and luminous, sitting cross-legged in the center of the lotus cores.

Then those lotuses went to every abode of the gods who dwell in the desire realm and the form realm: from the realm of the gods of the Four Great Kings, through the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, Yāma, Tuṣita, Nirmāṇarati, Paranirmitavaśavartin, Brahmakāyika, Brahmapāriṣadya, Brahmapurohita, Mahābrahmā, Parīttābha, Apramāṇābha, Ābhāsvara, Parīttaśubha, Apramāṇaśubha, Śubhakṛtsna, Anabhraka, Puṇyaprasava, Bṛhatphala, Avṛha, Atapa, Sudṛśa and Sudarśana, up to the realm of the gods of Akaniṣṭha; and likewise to all the abodes of the gods, from the billion realms of the gods of the Four Great Kings up to the realms of the gods of Akaniṣṭha, in this great trichiliocosm. There they made sounds resound, uttered melodies, and gave exhortation. As those bodily forms of bodhisattvas moved about through this great trichiliocosm, they spoke these verses:

"Buddhas, kinsmen of the sun,
appear in the world but rarely.
Like the udumbara flower,
so are buddhas exceedingly rare.

Śākyasiṃha, supreme among humans,
has appeared here in this world,
and he teaches the true Dharma
that brings all suffering to an end.

However long one may indulge
in the delightful pleasures of the gods,
one will go to the lower realms,
where one must undergo what one has earned.

As long as one pursues desires,
existence grows again and again.
For living beings who circle in the three realms
there is no happiness at all."

The arising of a buddha is exceedingly rare.
Those who have found the excellent leisure
Yet remain heedless and do not understand
Will not bring their suffering to an end.

So that you may see the Buddha, today
Listen to the excellent Dharma!
Once the Guide of the World has passed away,
Do not be filled with regret in times to come.

For those people who are always intoxicated
And who live in heedlessness,
Caught in the noose of Māra, the greatly terrifying,
How could there ever be liberation?

Now this is what should be proclaimed:
All you beings who have made merit,
Hurry to meet the perfect Buddha
Who bears the thirty-two marks!

Apart from the protectors of the world,
Whose loving-kindness is beyond conception,
Sentient beings have no other refuge,
Nor is there any other ally.

The Savior, Lion of the Śākyas,
Having practiced for ten million eons,
Immeasurable and inconceivable,
And having attained supreme wisdom,
Teaches the supreme Dharma,
In which no sentient being is apprehended
And there is neither life-force nor person,
Peaceful, profound, and hard to see.

Having fully abandoned permanence
And likewise annihilation,
He teaches living beings

The Dharma that has abandoned all signs.

He teaches emptiness, in which the world does not abide,
And signlessness,
And the true limit,
In which there is no wishing.

The Wise One teaches the Dharma
That has no mark and no sign,
That is unborn and without arising,
Without coming and without going.

Although he teaches what has no exhaustion and no arising,
What has no entity by intrinsic nature,
What cannot be seen and has no sign,
He has no conceited thought.

No sentient being whatsoever is born,
And no one at all dies.
There is no nirvāṇa whatsoever,
And no arising of sentient beings.

Although he teaches dharmas through speech,
He does not rely upon speech.
The Guide of Humankind teaches
The Dharma that is free of letters.

The One Endowed with Eyes teaches the Dharma
In which wind does not abide,
In which water and fire are not apprehended,
And in which there is no conceiving even of earth.

He teaches that form, feeling, perception,
Formations, and consciousness,
These five aggregates,
Are empty and without entity.

Although he teaches that eye, ear, nose,
Tongue, body, and likewise mind
Are empty of intrinsic nature,
That emptiness too is not apprehended.

Pleasing forms and sounds and smells,
Tastes and objects of touch,
Are produced by conceptual thought,
And conceptual thought too is empty of intrinsic nature.

Thus the Buddha, the Savior,
Teaches the Dharma to living beings.
Let all who wish to be freed from suffering
Come into the presence of the Guide!

Then, as those emanated bodhisattvas taught the Dharma with these verses in this great trichiliocosm, nine hundred sixty million of the gods who dwell in the desire realm and in the form realm obtained the dustless, stainless, pure Dharma eye regarding phenomena. Twelve thousand gods attained freedom from attachment. Three million two hundred thousand gods generated the mind set on awakening. Ten thousand gods who had properly entered the bodhisattva vehicle obtained acceptance of the nonarising of phenomena.

At that time, of the gods whom those bodhisattva forms had urged on, countless, immeasurable hundreds of thousands of gods, in an instant, a moment, a split second, went to where the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened Buddha Śākyamuni was. Having arrived, they bowed their heads at the Blessed One's feet, circumambulated the Blessed One three times, and sat down to one side. They strewed over the Tathāgata divine flowers, utpalas, kumudas, white lotuses, māndāravas, and great māndāravas, along with powders, incense, and ointments. In the sky above, many divine songs were sung as well.

At that time, in this world of four great continents, there was not a single spot of ground, not even the size of the point where a staff is planted, that was not filled by gods of great majesty, gods of great majesty; so many gods had gathered. And this world of four great continents was covered with flowers to the depth of the knees.

Then the god Susthitamati, the god Susīma, the god Vimala, and the god called Rich in Modesty, surrounded by and leading all the nine hundred sixty million gods, every one of whom had properly entered the bodhisattva vehicle, went to the dwelling of Mañjuśrī the Youthful. Having arrived, they circumambulated the dwelling of Mañjuśrī the Youthful seven times from outside and sent down showers of māndārava flowers. By those showers of māndārava flowers, a heap of flowers ten yojanas high came to stand all

around the dwelling of Mañjuśrī the Youthful.

Then Mañjuśrī the Youthful bestowed a blessing of such a kind that a net of flowers spread out everywhere in the sky above this great trichiliocosm, and the light of those flowers pervaded this entire great trichiliocosm. Then Mañjuśrī the Youthful came out of his dwelling and sat down on a seat that had arisen from aspiration. Then the god Susthitamati touched his head to both feet of Mañjuśrī the Youthful, and all those gods likewise touched their heads to both feet of Mañjuśrī the Youthful.

The Second Fascicle.

Then Mañjuśrī, who had become a youth, thought, "With whom shall I hold a dialogue of questions and answers in the presence of the Blessed One (the Buddha)? When these topics are taught, who will be a fit vessel for them? They are the inconceivable topics, the topics hard to understand, the topics without location, the topics without conceptual elaboration, the topics free of elaboration, the topics that cannot be expressed, the topics that cannot be shown, the profound topics, the topics of truth, the topics without attachment, the indivisible topics, the topics of emptiness, the topics of signlessness, the topics of wishlessness, the topics that teach suchness, the topics of the limit of reality, the topics of the realm of phenomena, the incomparable topics, the topics with nothing to take up, the topics with nothing to reject, the topics of the Buddha, the topics of the Dharma, the topics of the Saṅgha, the topics of attaining perfect wisdom, the topics of the sameness of the three realms, the topics of not apprehending any phenomenon, the topics that teach that no phenomenon arises, the topics of the lion, the topics of the hero. These are topics that have no basis."

Then Mañjuśrī, who had become a youth, thought again, "This son of the gods, Susthitamati, has rendered great service to the Victors of the past, has acceptance of the profound, and is endowed with unobstructed eloquence. So I shall hold a dialogue of questions and answers with him in the presence of the Blessed One."

Then Mañjuśrī, who had become a youth, said to the son of the gods Susthitamati, "Son of the gods, since you have acceptance of the profound and are endowed with unobstructed eloquence, are you able to hold a dialogue of questions and answers with me in the presence of the Blessed One?"

When he had said this, the son of the gods Susthitamati said to Mañjuśrī, who had become a youth, "Mañjuśrī, if you will not speak, will not utter, will not

recite, will not pronounce even a syllable, and will not hear a sound, then I shall teach accordingly."

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, if you will not listen, will not grasp, will not retain, will not comprehend, will not think, will not know, will not cognize, will not take up, will not give up, and, even having heard, will not teach it to others, then I too shall teach accordingly. Why is that? Son of the gods, it is because the awakening of the buddhas is without letters, without mind, and free of mind. It is expressed by a name, and that name too is unmoving."

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, these sons of the gods wish to hear the teaching of the Dharma from you. So please, right here in this place, give these sons of the gods a talk on the Dharma."

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, I do not teach the Dharma to those who wish to listen, nor to those who wish to grasp it. Why is that? Son of the gods, it is because if one grasps at a self, one becomes eager to listen, and if one grasps at a sentient being, grasps at a life, or grasps at a person, one becomes eager to listen.

"Son of the gods, whoever has the grasping at 'I' and the grasping at 'mine' thinks, 'This one is the teacher, I am the listener, this is what is to be explained.' Because he thinks this way, he is attached by three attachments. What are the three? Apprehending a self, apprehending a sentient being, and apprehending a phenomenon.

"Son of the gods, whoever has no grasping at 'I' and no grasping at 'mine' teaches the Dharma with the three spheres completely pure. He does not conceptualize, he does not think, he does not presume. And what is the complete purity of the three spheres? It is not apprehending a self, not conceptualizing, not presuming, not thinking; not apprehending a speaker of the Dharma, not conceptualizing, not presuming, not thinking; and not apprehending the Dharma, not conceptualizing, not presuming, not thinking. Son of the gods, those who listen in this way listen with evenness; they do not listen unevenly."

The son of the gods Susthitamati said, "Mañjuśrī, excellent, excellent, that you explain the teaching for the sake of irreversibility, whatever may come!"

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, do not conceptualize anything whatsoever. The bodhisattva who turns back is the one who fully and perfectly awakens to awakening, and yet awakening cannot be apprehended."

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, from what does he turn back?"

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, he turns back from attachment. He turns back from aversion. He turns back from delusion. He turns back from craving. He turns back from ignorance. He turns back from all twelve links of birth in saṃsāra. He turns back from causes. He turns back from views. He turns back from name. He turns back from form. He turns back from the desire realm. He turns back from the form realm. He turns back from the formless realm. He turns back from the conduct of the śrāvakas. He turns back from the conduct of the pratyekabuddhas. He turns back from conceptualization. He turns back from grasping. He turns back from signs. He turns back from grasping at things as real. He turns back from the view of annihilation. He turns back from the view of permanence. He turns back from taking up. He turns back from rejecting. He turns back from the perception of a self. He turns back from the perception of a sentient being. He turns back from the perception of a life. He turns back from the perception of a person. He turns back from mental engagements. He turns back from attachments. He turns back from the inverted views. He turns back from the perishable aggregate. He turns back from the view of the perishable aggregate. He turns back from the sixty-two kinds of view that arise from the root of the perishable aggregate. He turns back from the obscurations. He turns back from grasping at the five aggregates. He turns back from all the outer and inner sense sources. He turns back from the elements. He turns back from the perception of the Buddha. He turns back from the perception of the Dharma. He turns back from the perception of the Saṅgha. He turns back from those perceptions that think, 'I shall become a buddha, I shall teach the Dharma, I shall liberate sentient beings, I shall subdue Māra, I shall attain wisdom.' He does not conceptualize the ten powers of the Tathāgata. He does not conceptualize the eighteen unshared qualities of the Buddha.

He does not conceptualize the faculties, the powers, or the fearlessnesses. He does not conceptualize the major marks. He does not conceptualize the arrays of the buddha fields. He does not conceptualize the excellence of the Saṅgha of śrāvakas, and he turns away from all conceptualizing. Son of the gods, in this way a bodhisattva who turns away from these things is one who does not turn back.

The son of the gods asked, "Mañjuśrī, from what does he not turn back?"

Mañjuśrī replied, "Son of the gods, he does not turn back from the wisdom of the buddhas. He does not turn back from emptiness. He does not turn back from signlessness. He does not turn back from wishlessness. He does not turn back from suchness. He does not turn back from the realm of phenomena (dharmadhātu). He does not turn back from the very limit of reality. He does not turn back from sameness."

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, you have said that a bodhisattva who turns away from those phenomena of conceptualizing, conceptual thought, and imaginative construing is for that reason called 'one who turns away.' Do those phenomena from which he turns away exist? Or do they not exist? Or do they both exist and not exist? Or do they neither exist nor not exist?"

Mañjuśrī replied, "Son of the gods, those phenomena from which he turns away are not existent, they are not nonexistent, they are not both existent and nonexistent, and they are not neither existent nor nonexistent."

The son of the gods asked, "Mañjuśrī, then from what does he turn away?"

Mañjuśrī replied, "Son of the gods, whatever grasping is incorrect, whatever grasping is improper, whatever grasping is mistaken, he does not grasp it, he does not give it up, and he does not make it into a sign. For that reason he is called 'one who turns away.' It should not be taught as existent, nor should it be taught as nonexistent. Why is that? Because if he were to turn away from existence and nonexistence, that would be a fault. Why is that? Because if he were to turn away from existence, it would become eternalism, and if he were to turn away from nonexistence, it would become annihilationism. The Tathāgata does not teach the Dharma for the sake of permanence or annihilation. The Dharma taught by the buddhas, the blessed ones, is neither for the sake of permanence nor for the sake of annihilation. Son of the gods, as for suchness, it is simply that one fully understands as nonexistent the perception, 'It is something that had not come about before.' In it there is no annihilation, nor is there permanence. Son of the gods, it is in this way that a bodhisattva is one who turns away."

When this teaching was explained, ten thousand sons of the gods attained acceptance of the unborn nature of phenomena.

Then Susthitamati, the son of the gods, spoke these words to Mañjuśrī, the Youthful: "Mañjuśrī, please go into the presence of the Tathāgata in order to see him, pay homage to him, attend upon him, put questions to him, and make inquiries of him."

Mañjuśrī replied, "Son of the gods, do not engage in conceptual thought. I have already taken hold of the Tathāgata."

The son of the gods asked, "Mañjuśrī, where does the Tathāgata dwell?"

Mañjuśrī replied, "Son of the gods, he dwells in front of me."

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, he is not there."

Mañjuśrī replied, "Son of the gods, if you see everything, you will not thereby see the Tathāgata."

The son of the gods asked, "Mañjuśrī, why do you say, 'I have already taken hold of the Tathāgata, and he dwells in front of me'?"

Mañjuśrī replied, "Son of the gods, what do you think of this? What do you suppose it is that is called 'in front of me'?"

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, it is the element of space."

Mañjuśrī replied, "Son of the gods, the Tathāgata, too, is just that: the element of space. Why is that? Because all phenomena are equal to space, and just as space is, so too is the Tathāgata. Therefore space and the Tathāgata are not two, because they cannot be made into two. Son of the gods, therefore, if you wish to see the Tathāgata, you should understand this ultimate point and not conceptualize in the slightest."

Then, at that time, Mañjuśrī, the Youthful, emanated thirty-two thousand multistoried pavilions, square and symmetrical, each with four pillars, evenly proportioned, exceedingly beautiful, and delightful to behold. Within those pavilions he also emanated jeweled thrones spread with garments that came from the wish-fulfilling trees of the gods, and on each throne he emanated the bodily form of a bodhisattva endowed with the thirty-two major marks of a great being.

Then Mañjuśrī, the Youthful, empowered things with a blessing of such a kind that, by his having blessed them in this way, all the lotuses that ranged through this great trichiliocosm, together with those pavilions, went to where the Tathāgata was. Having arrived, they circumambulated the Blessed One and the Saṅgha of monks three times, and then they stood in the sky above, appearing over the circle of the Blessed One's assembly and encircling it on all four sides.

Then all the emanated bodhisattvas seated on those lotuses, and all the bodhisattvas seated in the pavilions, praised the Blessed One in unison with

these verses:

Countless as the Ganges' sands, beyond conception,
Many tens of millions of buddhas you have honored;
Because you sought the conduct of supreme awakening,
Therefore, supreme among humans, you are beautiful.

Sage, fully adorned with the major marks,
Your supreme body shines throughout the three realms of existence;
Guide, for whom there is no human being, no life-force,
And no person, you teach the Dharma to beings.

Guide, you practiced generosity and moral discipline,
And relied on patience, diligence, and likewise meditative concentration;
Your wisdom is unobstructed in the three realms of existence;
To you who have reached the end of primordial wisdom, I bow.

Whoever bows before the Lord of Dharma,
The guide of the world, worshipped by gods and humans,
And who has faith in emptiness:
That person will become a guide of the worlds.

The tathāgatas who came in the past,
And the guides who dwell in all the directions,
Have always cultivated the Dharma that teaches signlessness,
Which has no intrinsic nature and no characteristics.

Here no sentient being with an intrinsic nature,
No birth and no death, can be found;
There is no coming and there is no going;
All phenomena are just like space.

Just as an illusion conjured by a man
Appears, yet does not exist in reality,
So the Sugata taught that phenomena
Are like illusions and like dreams.

If some person were to give away as gifts
World systems as many as the sands of the Ganges,
The acceptance that conditioned things are empty
Is a patience that far surpasses that giving.

A bodhisattva who longs for awakening
Might, for koṭis of eons as many as the Ganges' sands,

Offer flowers, incense, food and drink,
Worshipping the Buddha, supreme among humans;
But whoever hears these teachings,
In which there is no one acting, no one acted upon, no human, no life and no person,
And gains a luminous acceptance of them:
It is that one who has truly honored the highest of humans.

One who holds the notion of a human or a person,
Even if for many koṭis of eons he gives
Food and drink, chariots, escorts, thrones and seats,
Will not thereby gain liberation here.

The supreme humans who have passed into nirvāṇa,
And who have also set many beings free,
Those wise ones were liberated by knowing in this way
That phenomena are by nature luminous and empty.

The appearance of a buddha, dwelling in a central land,
And likewise gaining faith in his teaching are hard to come by;
Since human existence too is hard to find,
Strive well in the teaching of the Victors.

Having left behind all the eight unfree states,
And gained the perfect freedom so hard to find,
The wise who have found faith in the Sugata's teaching
Practice the yoga that is fitting.

Do not dwell attached to mere words;
Having heard the Dharma, always with diligence
You should always resort to a solitary place,
And by that become the holiest of humans.

Rely on a spiritual friend who speaks the Dharma,
And never, not even once, rely on evil friends.
Keep your mind impartial toward all beings,
And never be conceited toward beings.

Be endowed with moral discipline and great learning;
Always keep to rag-heap robes and the alms round.
Without slackness, keep to the foot of a tree,

And do not scorn the excellent medicine of what is discarded.

All these conditioned things are not conditioned;
They have a single characteristic and are like a mirage.
Know the single limit of the ultimate,
And quickly touch immeasurable awakening.

Look upon the five aggregates as an illusion.
The six inner sense sources and the six outer:
Since these are said to be like an empty village,
Never rely upon them.

Attachment and aversion are by nature emptiness;
Delusion and pride are produced by conceptualization;
And that conceptualization has not arisen and will not arise.
If you know it thus, you will become guides.

Then, when those emanations had spoken these verses, twenty-two thousand living beings in that assembly generated the mind set on unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. The minds of five hundred monks were liberated from the defilements without clinging. For three hundred monks the Dharma eye regarding phenomena became pure, free of dust and free of stain. For three thousand nuns too the Dharma eye regarding phenomena became pure, free of dust and free of stain. For seven thousand laymen, a thousand laywomen and twenty-seven thousand sons of the gods too the Dharma eye regarding phenomena became pure, free of dust and free of stain. Three hundred bodhisattvas attained acceptance of the nonarising of phenomena. And this great trichiliocosm world system shook in six ways: it moved, moved strongly, moved strongly everywhere; it quaked, quaked strongly, quaked strongly everywhere; it trembled, trembled strongly, trembled strongly everywhere.

Then the elder Śāriputra said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, by whose power is it that this great trichiliocosm world system has shaken strongly in six ways, that the bodily forms of the bodhisattvas present in these lotuses and these pavilions are teaching such profound Dharma, that this assembly has been pervaded by a great light, that so many koṭis of sons of the gods have gathered, and that these many koṭis of bodhisattvas have gathered?"

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the elder Śāriputra, "Śāriputra, this is the power of the youthful Mañjuśrī; it is through him that all these arrays

appear. Why is that? Because, Śāriputra, today the youthful Mañjuśrī, together with Susthitamati, son of the gods, is going to ask and inquire of the Tathāgata about the Dharma discourse called Destroying All the Maṇḍalas of Māra, in order to bring to full accomplishment the inconceivable qualities of the Buddha."

When he had said this, the venerable Śāriputra said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, the youthful Mañjuśrī is not present in this gathered assembly."

The Blessed One said, "Śāriputra, wait a moment. In a short while the youthful Mañjuśrī, overpowering all the maṇḍalas of Māra, all the abodes of Māra and all the māras, will come with a great array to where the Tathāgata is."

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī entered into the meditative absorption called Destroying All the Maṇḍalas of Māra. The very moment the youthful Mañjuśrī entered into the meditative absorption of destroying all the maṇḍalas of Māra, immediately all the many hundreds of koṭis of abodes of Māra in this great trichiliocosm world system became dim and gloomy. Those wicked māras, too, found their own bodies grown old, decrepit and bent, and they went about leaning on staffs in their hands.

They saw that the goddesses too had grown old, decrepit and feeble, and that their own celestial palaces too had become old and dilapidated, were falling apart, and had sunk into pitch darkness. Then those evil māras were terrified and frightened, dejected and despondent, and the hair on their bodies stood on end. They thought, "What is the cause, and what is the condition, by which these abodes of ours, the abodes of Māra, have come to such a state? Surely we are going to die and pass away from here, or cease to exist altogether!"

The very moment those māras had this thought, Mañjuśrī Kumārabhūta emanated a billion gods (devaputras) and set them before those māras. Then the emanated gods said to the evil māras, "Friends, this is the power of the irreversible bodhisattva called Mañjuśrī Kumārabhūta, who is at this moment absorbed in the samādhi called Destroying All the Maṇḍalas of Māra. No harm whatsoever will come to you, so do not be afraid!"

As soon as the emanated gods had spoken these words, those evil māras heard the sound and also heard the name of Mañjuśrī Kumārabhūta. Then they became even more terrified and frightened, and all those abodes of Māra shook violently. Then the evil māras said to the emanated gods, "Friends, protect us! Friends, protect us!"

The emanated gods replied to the evil māras, "Friends, do not be afraid! Friends, do not be afraid! Go today to where the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Śākyamuni is. That compassionate Tathāgata grants fearlessness to beings who are afraid." Having spoken these words, the emanated gods vanished on the spot.

Then all those evil māras, together with their retinues of many billions of hundreds of thousands of evil māras, old and decrepit, aching, leaning on staffs as they went, in an instant, a moment, a split second, went to where the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha Śākyamuni was. When they arrived, they all spoke to the Blessed One with one voice, saying, "Blessed One, please protect us from these ugly states! Sugata, please protect us! Blessed One, when the names of a hundred thousand koṭis of buddhas are proclaimed, it makes no evident impression on us, but with the name of Mañjuśrī Kumārabhūta alone it is not so. And why? Because when we hear the name of Mañjuśrī Kumārabhūta, we become afraid, frightened and terrified, thinking that we will die and pass away, thinking that we will cease to exist."

Then the Blessed One said to the evil māras, "Evil ones, it is so. It is just as you have said. A hundred thousand koṭis of buddhas have not worked and do not work for the benefit of beings in the way that Mañjuśrī Kumārabhūta has brought them to maturity and, making no distinctions, has worked and will work for the benefit of beings. Therefore, the proclamation of the names of a hundred thousand koṭis of buddhas does not make you suffer and perish the way the proclamation of the name of Mañjuśrī Kumārabhūta alone does."

Then the evil māras said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, we are miserable and ashamed with these decrepit bodies. Blessed One, we wish to be as we were before, when our complexion was radiant."

The Blessed One said, "Remain right here for a while until Mañjuśrī Kumārabhūta arrives. He will free you completely from this ugly state."

Then Mañjuśrī Kumārabhūta arose from that samādhi and rose from his seat. Surrounded and preceded by many hundreds of thousands of bodhisattvas, and surrounded and preceded by many hundreds of thousands of gods, and by many hundreds of thousands of nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kiṃnaras and great mahoragas, every one of them playing many hundreds of thousands of cymbals and raining down utpala flowers, lotuses, kumuda flowers and white lotuses, he went with great splendor and great festivity to

where the Blessed One was. Having arrived, he bowed his head at the Blessed One's feet, circumambulated the Blessed One three times, and sat down to one side.

Then the Blessed One said to Mañjuśrī Kumārabhūta, "Mañjuśrī, do you enter the samādhi called Destroying All the Maṇḍalas of Māra?"

Mañjuśrī replied, "Blessed One, I do enter it."

The Blessed One said, "Mañjuśrī, from which tathāgata did you hear the samādhi that you accomplished? And how long has it been since you accomplished that samādhi?"

Mañjuśrī replied, "Blessed One, at the time I heard that samādhi which I accomplished, and when I accomplished that samādhi, the Blessed One had not yet even given rise to the mind set on awakening."

The Blessed One said, "Mañjuśrī, what was the name of that tathāgata from whom you heard of the accomplishment of samādhi that you achieved?"

Mañjuśrī replied, "Blessed One, long ago, in times past, eons ago, inconceivable and still more inconceivable, countless and still more countless eons ago, at that time and in that age there appeared a tathāgata called Mandāravagandha, endowed with knowledge and conduct, a sugata, a knower of the world, an unsurpassed guide who tames beings, a teacher of gods and humans, a buddha, a blessed one. He taught that accomplishment of samādhi, and from that tathāgata I heard of the accomplishment of the samādhi that destroys all the maṇḍalas of Māra."

The Blessed One said, "Mañjuśrī, what does that accomplishment consist of?"

Mañjuśrī replied, "Blessed One, when a bodhisattva possesses twenty aspects, he attains the samādhi that destroys all the maṇḍalas of Māra. What are the twenty? Blessed One, here a bodhisattva destroys attachment and destroys the mind of attachment. He destroys aversion and destroys the mind of aversion. He destroys delusion and destroys the mind of delusion. He destroys jealousy and destroys the mind of jealousy. He destroys pride and destroys the mind of pride. He destroys concealment and destroys the mind of concealment. He destroys anger and destroys the mind of anger. He destroys torment and destroys the mind of torment. He destroys perception and destroys the mind of perception. He destroys views and destroys the mind of views. He destroys conceptual thought and destroys the mind of conceptual thought. He destroys appropriation and destroys the mind of appropriation. He

destroys grasping and destroys the mind of grasping. He destroys signs and destroys the mind of signs. He destroys existence and destroys the mind of existence. He destroys permanence and destroys the mind of permanence. He destroys annihilation and destroys the mind of annihilation. He destroys the aggregates and destroys the mind of the aggregates. He destroys the elements and destroys the mind of the elements. He destroys the sense bases and destroys the mind of the sense bases. He destroys the three realms and destroys the mind that takes the three realms as its object. Blessed One, when a bodhisattva possesses these twenty aspects, he attains that samādhi.

"Furthermore, Blessed One, when a bodhisattva possesses four qualities, he attains that samādhi. What are the four? He genuinely enters into the superior intention, he is unwavering, he is profound, and he gives away all his possessions. Blessed One, when a bodhisattva possesses these four qualities, he attains that samādhi.

"Furthermore, Blessed One, when a bodhisattva possesses four qualities, he attains that samādhi. What are the four? He is without deceit, he makes his promises with truthful words, he does not fall within the domain ruled by perception, and he does not grasp at any phenomena. Blessed One, when a bodhisattva possesses these four qualities, he attains that samādhi.

"Furthermore, Blessed One, when a bodhisattva possesses four qualities, he attains that samādhi. What are the four? He relies on spiritual friends, he gives up evil companions, he is endowed with ascetic training, moral discipline, and few requisites, and he lives free from bustle. Blessed One, when a bodhisattva possesses these four qualities, he attains that samādhi.

"Furthermore, Blessed One, when a bodhisattva possesses four qualities, he attains that samādhi. What are the four? His moral discipline is unbroken, his moral discipline is untorn, his moral discipline is not dependent, and his moral discipline is without blemish. Blessed One, when a bodhisattva possesses these four qualities, he attains that samādhi.

"Furthermore, Blessed One, when a bodhisattva possesses four qualities, he attains that samādhi. What are the four? He completely abandons the mind of the śrāvakas, he does not particularly focus on the mind of the pratyekabuddhas, he abides in patience, and he has no conceit toward sentient beings. Blessed One, when a bodhisattva possesses these four qualities, he attains that samādhi.

"Furthermore, Blessed One, when a bodhisattva possesses four qualities, he attains that samādhi. What are the four? He cultivates the Dharma of emptiness and has no conceit about persons; he cultivates signlessness and completely abandons signs; he cultivates wishlessness and completely abandons the mind of wishing; and he knows the proper procedure and gives away all things. These are the four. Blessed One, when a bodhisattva possesses these aspects and these qualities, he attains the samādhi that destroys all the maṇḍalas of Māra.

"Blessed One, in this way the Tathāgata Mandāravagandha fully taught that accomplishment of samādhi. Blessed One, I heard that accomplishment of samādhi from that tathāgata. Blessed One, after the Tathāgata Mandāravagandha there appeared the tathāgata, arhat, perfectly complete buddha called Light Outshining All Jewels, Gems, Lightning, Sun and Moon, and Blessed One, in the presence of that tathāgata I accomplished that samādhi."

When this teaching was given, ten thousand bodhisattvas in that assembly accomplished that samādhi. Then the elder Śāriputra said this to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, it is wonderful how well the youthful Mañjuśrī has accomplished that samādhi, and how, by accomplishing that samādhi, he has made these evil māras so ugly."

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Śāriputra: "Śāriputra, you might think, 'Only the evil māras of this great trichiliocosm world system have been made ugly in this way.' Śāriputra, you should not see it like that. And why? Śāriputra, it is because, through the blessing of the youthful Mañjuśrī, all the evil māras dwelling in the buddhafields of all ten directions, as many as the sands of the river Ganges, have come into this same condition."

Then the Blessed One said to the youthful Mañjuśrī, "Mañjuśrī, release this blessing, and make these evil māras regain the full splendor of their former complexion."

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī released the blessing. The very moment the blessing was released, those evil māras regained the full splendor of their former complexion.

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī said to those evil māras and to the retinues of Māra: "Evil ones, in whomever there is the eye, in whomever there is

perception of the eye, in whomever there is clinging to the eye, in whomever there is the sign of the eye, in whomever there is focusing on the eye, in whomever there is attachment to the eye, in whomever there is conceit about the eye, in whomever there is appropriation of the eye as one's own, in whomever there is reliance on the eye, in whomever there is fixation on the eye, in whomever there is conceptual elaboration of the eye, in whomever there is the eye as mine, in whomever there is guarding of the eye, in whomever there is cultivation of the eye, in whomever there is taking up of the eye, in whomever there is discarding of the eye, in whomever there is conceiving of the eye, in whomever there is thinking about the eye, in whomever there is accomplishment of the eye, in whomever there is cessation of the eye, in whomever there is arising of the eye, in whomever there is grasping at the eye, in whomever there is coming of the eye, in that one you have scope for your work of Māra, the making of obstacles.

"Evil ones, likewise, in whomever there is the ear, the nose, the tongue, the body, the mind, form, sound, smell, taste, the tangible, and phenomena, in whomever there is perception of phenomena, in whomever there is clinging to phenomena, in whomever there is the sign of phenomena, in whomever there is focusing on phenomena, in whomever there is attachment to phenomena, in whomever there is conceit about phenomena, in whomever there is appropriation of phenomena as one's own, in whomever there is reliance on phenomena, in whomever there is fixation on phenomena, in whomever there is conceptual elaboration of phenomena, in whomever there is phenomena as mine, in whomever there is guarding of phenomena, in whomever there is cultivation of phenomena, in whomever there is taking up of phenomena, in whomever there is discarding of phenomena, in whomever there is conceiving of phenomena, in whomever there is thinking about phenomena, in whomever there is accomplishment of phenomena, in whomever there is cessation of phenomena, in whomever there is arising of phenomena, in whomever there is grasping at phenomena, in whomever there is coming of phenomena, in that one you have scope for your work of Māra, the making of obstacles.

"Evil ones, in whomever there is no eye, in whomever there is no perception of the eye, in whomever there is no clinging to the eye, in whomever there is no sign of the eye, in whomever there is no focusing on the eye, in whomever there is no attachment to the eye, in whomever there is no conceit about the eye, in whomever there is no appropriation of the eye as one's own, in whomever there is no reliance on the eye, in whomever there is no fixation on

the eye, in whomever there is no conceptual elaboration of the eye, in whomever there is no eye as mine, in whomever there is no guarding of the eye, in whomever there is no cultivation of the eye, in whomever there is no taking up of the eye, in whomever there is no discarding of the eye, in whomever there is no conceiving of the eye, in whomever there is no thinking about the eye, in whomever there is no accomplishment of the eye, in whomever there is no cessation of the eye, in whomever there is no arising of the eye, in whomever there is no grasping at the eye, in whomever there is no coming of the eye, in that one you have no place. You have no domain. You have no mastery. You have no power. You have no dominion. You have no hold by force.

"Evil ones, likewise, in whomever there is no ear, nose, tongue, body, mind, form, sound, smell, taste, tangible, or phenomena, in whomever there is no perception of phenomena, in whomever there is no clinging to phenomena, in whomever there is no sign of phenomena, in whomever there is no focusing on phenomena, in whomever there is no attachment to phenomena, in whomever there is no conceit about phenomena, in whomever there is no appropriation of phenomena as one's own, in whomever there is no reliance on phenomena, in whomever there is no fixation on phenomena, in whomever there is no conceptual elaboration of phenomena, in whomever there is no phenomena as mine, in whomever there is no guarding of phenomena, in whomever there is no cultivation of phenomena, in whomever there is no taking up of phenomena, in whomever there is no discarding of phenomena, in whomever there is no conceiving of phenomena, in whomever there is no thinking about phenomena, in whomever there is no accomplishment of phenomena, in whomever there is no cessation of phenomena, in whomever there is no arising of phenomena, in whomever there is no grasping at phenomena, in whomever there is no coming of phenomena, in that one you have no place. You have no domain. You have no mastery. You have no power. You have no dominion. You have no hold by force."

Then, through this teaching of the Dharma given by the youthful Mañjuśrī in this way, ten thousand māras from that retinue of Māra generated the mind set on unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. For eighty-four thousand māras from that retinue of Māra, the Dharma eye regarding phenomena became purified, dustless and free of stain.

Then the elder Mahākāśyapa said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, the youthful Mañjuśrī is here, yet, Blessed One, we would like to see those

bodhisattvas. And why? Because, Blessed One, such holy beings as these are hard to behold."

Then the Blessed One said to Mañjuśrī, the youthful one, "Mañjuśrī, this assembly wishes to see the bodhisattvas who have gathered from the ten directions. You must show them."

Then Mañjuśrī, the youthful one, spoke to the bodhisattvas Dharma, Dharmodgata, Dharmamati, Sūrya, Weapon of Māra, Mañjughoṣa, Pacifier of Evil, Śāntarakṣita, Guardian of Victory and Renowned Dharma King, and to the other bodhisattvas as well: "Sons of good family, show your own bodies just as the bodies of bodhisattvas are in each of your own buddhafields."

As soon as Mañjuśrī, the youthful one, had spoken these words, at that very moment those bodhisattvas arose from their meditative absorption, and having arisen, each displayed his own body.

Then the bodies of some bodhisattvas were as large as Mount Meru. The bodies of some were eighty thousand yojanas. The bodies of some were seventy thousand, sixty thousand, fifty thousand, forty thousand, thirty thousand, twenty thousand or ten thousand yojanas. The bodies of some were five thousand, four thousand, three thousand, two thousand or one thousand yojanas. The bodies of some were five hundred, four hundred, three hundred, two hundred or one hundred yojanas. The bodies of some were fifty, forty, thirty, twenty or ten yojanas. The bodies of some were five, four, three, two or one yojana. The bodies of some bodhisattvas were about three and a half cubits, the size of the bodies of the beings of this Sahā world. Such bodies of theirs appeared everywhere.

At that time, in this great trichiliocosm, there was not a single spot, not even the size of the place where a staff is planted, that was not filled entirely with bodhisattvas of great splendor, of great splendor. By the light of those bodhisattvas, a hundred thousand koṭis of buddhafields in the ten directions were also illuminated.

Then Mañjuśrī, the youthful one, rose from his seat, draped his upper robe over one shoulder, and placed his right knee on the ground. Bowing with palms joined toward the Blessed One, he addressed the Blessed One with these words: "If the Blessed One grants me the opportunity to have my questions answered once I have asked them, I would ask the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, about a few points."

When he had made this request, the Blessed One spoke to Mañjuśrī, the youthful one, with these words: "Mañjuśrī, ask the Tathāgata whatever you wish, and by answering each and every one of your questions I shall delight your mind."

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, Mañjuśrī, the youthful one, and the entire assembly listened to the Blessed One, and Mañjuśrī addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, one speaks of a 'bodhisattva, a bodhisattva.' Blessed One, why is one called a bodhisattva?"

When he had asked this, the Blessed One spoke to Mañjuśrī, the youthful one, with these words: "Mañjuśrī, one is called a bodhisattva because one understands all phenomena. Mañjuśrī, if one asks what all those phenomena are, by understanding which one is called a bodhisattva, a bodhisattva: Mañjuśrī, here the bodhisattva understands the eye. He understands the ear. He understands the nose. He understands the tongue. He understands the body. He understands the mind.

"Mañjuśrī, if one asks how the bodhisattva understands the eye, and how he understands the ear, nose, tongue, body and mind: Mañjuśrī, here the bodhisattva understands that the eye is empty of intrinsic nature, yet he does not conceive the thought, 'I understand.' He understands that the ear, nose, tongue, body and mind are empty of intrinsic nature, yet he does not conceive the thought, 'I understand.' He understands that forms, sounds, smells, tastes, tangibles and mental phenomena are empty of intrinsic nature, yet he does not conceive the thought, 'I understand.'

"Furthermore, Mañjuśrī, the bodhisattva understands the five aggregates of appropriation. If one asks how he understands them: he understands them as emptiness. He understands them as signless. He understands them as wishless. He understands them as free from attachment. He understands them as peaceful. He understands them as isolated. He understands them as without entity. He understands them as unmoving. He understands them as without arising. He understands them as without coming. He understands them as without going. He understands them as without essential nature. He understands them as without owner. He understands them as without cognition. He understands them as without knowing. He understands them as without seeing. He understands them as unborn. He understands them as free from conceptual elaboration. He understands them as without anything belonging to a self. He understands them as produced by conceptual thought.

He understands them as produced by discursive thought. He understands them as dependent origination. He understands them as like an illusion. He understands them as like a dream. He understands them as like a mirage. He understands them as like an echo. He understands them as like the core of a plantain tree. He understands them as not lasting long, as without core, as hollow and as void.

"Furthermore, Mañjuśrī, the bodhisattva understands attachment. He understands aversion. He understands delusion."

How does one realize them? One realizes that attachment, aversion, and delusion are brought about by thorough conceptualization. And one realizes those conceptualizations as well to be empty, nonexistent, without entity, free of conceptual elaboration, and without cognition.

Furthermore, Mañjuśrī, the bodhisattva realizes the desire realm. He realizes the form realm and the formless realm. How does he realize them? He fully realizes them as selfless, empty, and void.

Furthermore, Mañjuśrī, the bodhisattva realizes the conduct of sentient beings. How does he realize it? He realizes, "These beings act out of attachment. These act out of aversion. These act out of delusion. These act out of all three in equal measure." Having realized this, he realizes skill in their conduct. He also realizes whatever teaching would bring them to understanding. Having realized it, he teaches the Dharma in whatever way will liberate them.

Furthermore, Mañjuśrī, the bodhisattva realizes all sentient beings. How does he realize them? All sentient beings are mere names, and that name too is unmoving. All these sentient beings are a single being, and that being too is no being. Thus he does not conceptualize, and for that reason he is called a bodhisattva. When the bodhisattva realizes all phenomena, then he realizes awakening.

On this it is said:

Though one realizes the eyes and ears
To be empty by their intrinsic nature,
One who does not think, "I have realized,"
Is called a bodhisattva.

Though one realizes the nose and tongue
To be without entity by their intrinsic nature,
One who does not think, "I have realized,"

Is called a bodhisattva.

The wise one realizes the body
And the mind to be empty,
And having realized this, teaches it correctly:
Such a one is called a bodhisattva.

Forms and sounds and scents,
Tastes and pleasing objects of touch:
One who realizes them all to be empty
Is called a bodhisattva.

One realizes form and feeling,
And perception likewise;
Formations and consciousness
One realizes to be like illusions.

The five aggregates are like a dream,
Without characteristics, of a single mark;
Though realizing this, one who does not think, "I have realized,"
Is called a bodhisattva.

Inwardly nothing has arisen;
It is free of elaboration and unconditioned.
These things are taught by means of names,
And those names are not existent things.

One realizes that attachment and aversion
Are brought about by conceptualization;
That realization too does not arise:
It is utterly without entity.

Delusion arises from conceptual thought;
Conceptual thought is born from a cause;
The cause, too, is produced by views,
And those views cannot be apprehended.

The three realms are all empty;
One realizes them as nonexistent.
One for whom nothing here transmigrates at all
Is called a bodhisattva.

The desire realm is not established;
It is brought about by conceptual thought.
The form and formless realms are likewise:
None of them exists.

Conduct of attachment, conduct of aversion,
And likewise conduct of delusion:
Whatever the conduct of beings may be,
The skilled one realizes it all.

All sentient beings are a single being,
And that being too does not exist.
Though the wise one realizes this,
He has no conceit regarding that being.

The arising of all phenomena
Is born from the inversions;
Whatever conceives in inverted ways,
That is the mark of what is wrong.

One skilled in every kind of knowledge
Has no attachment even to any word;
One who has realized nonattachment
Is called a bodhisattva.

Though giving away one's own flesh,
One does not dwell upon it;
One who realizes things as they are
Is called a bodhisattva.

Though one has perfected moral discipline,
One has no conceit about discipline;
The meaning of the way of the buddhas
Is unborn and unarisen.

Though pervading beings with loving-kindness,
One finds no being to apprehend;
One understands that the meaning of "being"
Is something taught by means of names.

Reflecting thoroughly on all conditioned things,
One abides in the undertaking of diligence,
And knowing the world to be empty,

One realizes supreme awakening.

Though one cultivates meditative concentration,
One has no reliance upon it;
Without abode, without any object:
Thus the wise one meditates.

Though with the weapon of wisdom one cuts off
The afflictions of habitual tendencies and views,
In the sphere of reality there is no conceit
Of dividing or of cutting.

The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra, The Prophecy Requested by the Divine Son Susthitamati. The third fascicle.

Then Mañjuśrī the Youthful said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, it is said, 'A bodhisattva who possesses the first generation of the mind, who possesses the first generation of the mind.' Blessed One, to what extent is a bodhisattva said to possess the first generation of the mind?"

The Blessed One said, "Mañjuśrī, a bodhisattva who generates perception and mental attention toward everything of the three realms is said to possess the first generation of the mind."

Mañjuśrī said, "As I understand the meaning of what the Blessed One has said, a bodhisattva who generates attachment, generates aversion, and generates delusion is said to possess the first generation of the mind."

Then the divine son Susthitamati said this to Mañjuśrī the Youthful: "Mañjuśrī, if generating attachment, aversion, and delusion were the bodhisattva's first generation of the mind, then even childish ordinary people would possess the first generation of the mind. Why is that? Because, Mañjuśrī, they generate attachment, aversion, and delusion."

Mañjuśrī said, "Divine son, childish ordinary people are unable to generate attachment, aversion, and delusion."

"Why is that? Because, Devaputra, attachment, aversion, and delusion are generated by the buddhas, the pratyekabuddhas, the śrāvakas, and the irreversible bodhisattvas."

The devaputra said, "Mañjuśrī, if this assembly does not understand and grasp the intended meaning of your words, they will come to have doubts. Therefore

please explain it, setting it out clearly."

Mañjuśrī said, "Devaputra, what do you think? When a winged bird moves through the sky above, does it fly off and go, or does it stay?"

The devaputra said, "Mañjuśrī, it flies off and goes."

Mañjuśrī said, "Devaputra, it was with that in mind that I spoke as I did, teaching that those who generate attachment, aversion, and delusion are called buddhas, pratyekabuddhas, śrāvakas, and irreversible bodhisattvas.

"Devaputra, that in which there is no support is arising. That in which there is no fixation is arising. That in which there is no clinging is arising. Devaputra, that in which there is no support, no fixation, and no clinging is arising, and what is called arising is without a basis. What is called arising is the ground where there is nothing to examine. What is called arising is the ground of non-occurrence. What is called arising is the ground of no essential nature. What is called arising is the ground of no entity. What is called arising is the ground of no coming. What is called arising is the ground of no going. What is called arising is the ground of non-arising. What is called arising is the ground of no reference point. What is called arising is the ground of no cognizing. What is called arising is the ground of no dust. What is called arising is the ground of no conceit. What is called arising is the ground of no activity. What is called arising is the ground of the inexpressible. What is called arising is the ground of the indivisible. What is called arising is the ground of no letters. What is called arising is the ground where there is nothing to grasp. What is called arising is the ground of no abode. What is called arising is the ground where there is nothing to take up. What is called arising is the ground where there is nothing to discard. What is called arising is the ground of what cannot be turned back.

"Devaputra, not to be conceited about that phenomenon, not to cling to it, not to think of it, not to know it, not to see it, not to hear it, not to cognize it, not to take it up, not to give it away, not to produce it, and not to stop it: that is the bodhisattva's first generation of the mind.

"Therefore, Devaputra, by that approach, by that dharmadhātu, by that sameness, by that limit, and by that skill in means, a bodhisattva should generate attachment. He should generate aversion and delusion. He should generate the support of the eye, and so on up to the support of the mind. He should generate fixation on form, and so on up to fixation on consciousness. He should generate name. He should generate form. He should generate

cause. He should generate every kind of view. He should generate ignorance. He should generate craving for existence, and so on up to entering into the twelve links of dependent origination. He should generate the five sense pleasures. He should generate clinging to the three realms. He should generate grasping at 'I' and grasping at 'mine.' He should generate the perishing collection. He should generate the view of the perishing collection. He should generate the sixty-two kinds of view. He should generate the perception of the Buddha, the perception of the Dharma, and the perception of the Saṅgha. He should generate the perception of self and the perception of other. He should generate the perception of earth. He should generate the perception of water, the perception of fire, the perception of wind, the perception of space, and the perception of consciousness. He should generate the four inversions. He should generate the five obscurations, the four stations of consciousness, the eight wrong states, and the ten paths of nonvirtuous action.

"Devaputra, in brief, a bodhisattva should generate all thoughts, all imaginings, all conceptual thoughts, all signs, all conceptual elaborations, all desires, all grasping, all clinging, all perceptions, all conceits, and all attachments. Devaputra, in this way you should understand that whatever is without clinging and without fixation regarding that phenomenon is what is called arising."

Then the Blessed One (the Buddha) gave his approval to Mañjuśrī the youthful, saying, "Excellent! Mañjuśrī, because you have honored and served as many blessed buddhas as there are grains of sand in the river Ganges, you have taught this first arising of mind of bodhisattvas. Excellent, excellent!"

Then the venerable Śāriputra said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, this arising of mind that Mañjuśrī the youthful has thus taught as the bodhisattva's first arising of mind is equal to attaining acceptance of the non-arising of phenomena."

The Blessed One said, "Śāriputra, so it is. It is just as you have said. Śāriputra, when the Tathāgata Dīpaṃkara prophesied to me, 'Brahmin youth, in the future, after countless eons, you will become the tathāgata, arhat, perfectly complete buddha called Śākyamuni,' at that time, Śāriputra, I was not separated from this arising of mind. Śāriputra, the acceptance of the non-arising of phenomena that I attained then, and that first arising of mind of a bodhisattva, is just what Mañjuśrī the youthful has taught."

Mañjuśrī said, "As I understand the meaning of what the Blessed One (the Buddha) has said, every arising of a bodhisattva's mind is the first arising of mind. Why is that? Because, Blessed One, every arising of mind is in fact nonarising, and whatever is nonarising is the first arising of a bodhisattva's mind."

When this teaching was explained, twenty-three thousand bodhisattvas attained forbearance regarding nonarising phenomena. The minds of five hundred monks were liberated from the defilements without clinging. For six hundred million young gods, the Dharma eye regarding phenomena became pure, free of dust and stainless.

Then the elder Mahākāśyapa said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, by teaching the Dharma in this way the youthful Mañjuśrī has brought benefit to so many beings. The youthful Mañjuśrī is doing what is difficult."

Mañjuśrī said, "Venerable Mahākāśyapa, I am not doing what is difficult. Why is that? Venerable Mahākāśyapa, all phenomena are without an agent, unmade, and without activity, and so I do not make any phenomenon at all, nor do I destroy one. I do not liberate any being at all, nor do I bind one. Why is that? Because there are no beings. Furthermore, Venerable Mahākāśyapa, as for saying that someone is doing what is difficult: Venerable Mahākāśyapa, I am not one who does what is difficult; nor is the Tathāgata, nor are the arhats, nor are the pratyekabuddhas. Venerable Mahākāśyapa, those who would say that it is childish ordinary beings who do what is difficult would be speaking correctly. Why is that? Venerable Mahākāśyapa, because what all the buddhas have not found, do not find, and will not find, and what all the śrāvakas and all the pratyekabuddhas have not found, do not find, and will not find, that is found by childish ordinary beings."

Mahākāśyapa said, "Mañjuśrī, what is it that all the buddhas have not found?"

Mañjuśrī said, "Venerable Mahākāśyapa, they have not found a self. They have not found a sentient being. They have not found a life force. They have not found a person. They have not found permanence. They have not found annihilation. They have not found the aggregates. They have not found the elements. They have not found the sense sources. They have not found name. They have not found form. They have not found the desire realm. They have not found the form realm. They have not found the formless realm. They have not found conception, thorough conception, conceptual thought, causes, or births. They have not found the inversions. They have not found attachment,

aversion, or delusion. They have not found this world or the world beyond. They have not found grasping at 'I' or grasping at 'mine.' In brief, Venerable Mahākāśyapa, they have not found any phenomenon, nor destroyed it, nor released it, nor grasped it, nor given it up, nor joined it, nor separated it.

"Venerable Mahākāśyapa, in this way you should understand that what all the buddhas have not found is found by childish ordinary beings who lack learning, and that is why they are the ones who do what is difficult. Moreover, what the buddhas have not done, and what the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas have not done, that too childish ordinary beings do."

Mahākāśyapa said, "Mañjuśrī, what is it that they do?"

Mañjuśrī said, "Venerable Mahākāśyapa, they make permanence. They make annihilation. They make fetters. They make fixations. They make conceit. They make intention. They make arising. They make destruction. They take up. They cast away. They proliferate. They conceptualize. They become attached. They become angry. They become puffed up. They abase themselves. Venerable Mahākāśyapa, since childish ordinary beings do those things that the buddhas, the blessed ones, have not done, do not do, and will not do, they are the ones who do what is difficult."

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, people speak of 'forbearance regarding nonarising phenomena, forbearance regarding nonarising phenomena.' Blessed One, what is it that is called a bodhisattva's forbearance regarding nonarising phenomena? And what does a bodhisattva who has attained forbearance regarding nonarising phenomena attain?"

The Blessed One said, "Mañjuśrī, it is called the attainment of forbearance regarding nonarising phenomena because there is nothing whatsoever to be attained. Why is that? Because that forbearance is without attainment; being without attainment, it is free from attainment, unattained, and undestroyed."

"Mañjuśrī, what is called forbearance toward unproduced phenomena is to accept that all phenomena are unproduced, to accept that all phenomena have no coming, to accept that all phenomena have no going, to accept that all phenomena have no equal, to accept that all phenomena have no owner, to accept that all phenomena have nothing to be taken up, to accept that all phenomena have nothing to be cast away, to accept that all phenomena are without real entity, to accept that all phenomena are without essential nature, to accept that all phenomena have no likeness, to accept that all phenomena

are free of dust and like space, to accept that all phenomena are indivisible and cannot be cut apart, to accept that all phenomena are without thorough affliction, to accept that all phenomena are without purification, to accept that all phenomena are empty, signless, and wishless, to accept that all phenomena are free of attachment, free of aversion, and free of delusion, and to accept that all phenomena abide in suchness, in the realm of phenomena (dharmadhātu), and in the limit of reality.

"It is to accept that all phenomena are unexamined, unanalyzed, unconceited, unelaborated, unthought, and unmade; that they are powerless and feeble, hollow and vain; that they are like an illusion, like a dream, like an echo, like an optical illusion, like a mirage, like the core of a plantain tree, like a water bubble, and like a mass of foam. It is to accept that these are neither phenomena nor non-phenomena, that they are merely expressed by names, and that those names too are unmoving and by their intrinsic nature isolated. In this way one accepts it, is devoted to it, has faith in it, enters into it, and examines it, without wavering, without doubt, without fear, without terror, and without becoming terrified. Having touched it with the body, one accomplishes it and abides in it, yet one does not apprehend a body, nor does one apprehend an abiding. That, Mañjuśrī, is called the bodhisattva's forbearance toward unproduced phenomena, because no sign whatsoever is in operation."

Mañjuśrī said, "Blessed One, what is called forbearance, forbearance, is this: that in which no phenomenon whatsoever is wounded by any phenomenon whatsoever. That is called forbearance."

Then the god's son Susthitamati said this to the youthful Mañjuśrī: "Mañjuśrī, which phenomenon is wounded by which phenomenon?"

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, the eye is wounded by pleasing and unpleasing forms. The ear is wounded by sounds, the nose by smells, the tongue by tastes, and the body by tangibles. God's son, the mind is wounded by pleasing and unpleasing phenomena.

"God's son, although a bodhisattva sees forms with the eye, he does not grasp them as signs, does not grasp them as marks, does not conceive of them, does not conceptualize them, does not become attached to them, and does not become angry at them. He knows forms to be empty by their intrinsic nature, does not regard them with conceit, and is not wounded. Likewise, although he hears sounds with the ear, smells odors with the nose, tastes flavors with the tongue, touches tangibles with the body, and knows phenomena with the

mind, he does not grasp them as signs, does not grasp them as marks, does not conceive of them, does not conceptualize them, does not become attached to them, and does not become angry at them. He knows phenomena to be empty by their intrinsic nature, does not regard them with conceit, and is not wounded.

"God's son, in this way he is not attached to the six sense sources and is not wounded by them. That which is not being wounded is called forbearance. God's son, a bodhisattva who has attained such forbearance does not conceive of phenomena as arising or as not arising. He does not conceive of phenomena as defiled or undefiled, as blameworthy or blameless, as conditioned or unconditioned. When he does not conceive, at that time it is called forbearance toward unproduced phenomena."

When this teaching was explained, sixty-two thousand living beings gave rise to the mind set on unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, and twelve thousand bodhisattvas attained forbearance toward unproduced phenomena.

Then the god's son Susthitamati said this to the youthful Mañjuśrī: "Mañjuśrī, since one speaks of advancing from ground to ground, how does a bodhisattva advance from ground to ground?"

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, ask the one who advances from ground to ground."

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, does a bodhisattva not advance from ground to ground and tread them all up to the tenth ground?"

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, do you not believe what the Blessed One said, that all phenomena are like an illusion?"

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, I do believe it."

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, then does an illusion or an emanation advance from ground to ground and tread them all up to the tenth ground?"

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, it does not."

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, when an illusion or an emanation comes to advance from ground to ground, then I too shall advance from ground to ground. Why is that? Because the Blessed One said that all phenomena are like an illusion. God's son, be that as it may, the teaching of advancing from ground to ground should be taught as no advancing; it is not advancing."

Why is that? Because all phenomena are without transference: phenomena do not transfer into other phenomena. Form does not transfer into feeling, nor

does feeling transfer into form. Form does not transfer into perception, nor does perception transfer into form. Form does not transfer into formations, nor do formations transfer into form. Form does not transfer into consciousness, nor does consciousness transfer into form. Feeling does not transfer into perception, nor does perception transfer into feeling. Feeling does not transfer into formations, nor do formations transfer into feeling. Feeling does not transfer into consciousness, nor does consciousness transfer into feeling. Perception does not transfer into formations, nor do formations transfer into perception. Perception does not transfer into consciousness, nor does consciousness transfer into perception. Formations do not transfer into consciousness, nor does consciousness transfer into formations.

The eye does not transfer into the ear, nor does the ear transfer into the eye. The eye does not transfer into the nose, nor does the nose transfer into the eye. The eye does not transfer into the tongue, nor does the tongue transfer into the eye. The eye does not transfer into the body, nor does the body transfer into the eye. The eye does not transfer into the mind, nor does the mind transfer into the eye. The ear does not transfer into the nose, nor does the nose transfer into the ear. The ear does not transfer into the tongue, nor does the tongue transfer into the ear. The ear does not transfer into the body, nor does the body transfer into the ear. The ear does not transfer into the mind, nor does the mind transfer into the ear. The nose does not transfer into the tongue, nor does the tongue transfer into the nose. The nose does not transfer into the body, nor does the body transfer into the nose. The nose does not transfer into the mind, nor does the mind transfer into the nose. The tongue does not transfer into the body, nor does the body transfer into the tongue. The tongue does not transfer into the mind, nor does the mind transfer into the tongue. The body does not transfer into the mind, nor does the mind transfer into the body.

These phenomena have distinct spheres of activity and distinct objects. They are dull, inert, without intention, unmoving, without agency; they appear like grass and walls; like an illusion they are without cognition; and they have a single characteristic, namely the absence of characteristics. For they do not transfer, they do not come, and they do not go.

Son of the gods, the bodhisattva who understands things in this way does not transfer into any phenomenon at all, does not conceptualize the grounds, does not see any advance to a ground, and does not abandon any ground. Because there is no transference and no destruction, he does not turn back from

awakening. Why is that? Because all phenomena are completely pure from the very beginning, the essential nature of the aggregates, the elements, and the sense sources is without transference and without destruction. Son of the gods, that is the bodhisattvas' advance from ground to ground.

Son of the gods, it is like this. Suppose, for example, a magician were to conjure up a building of ten storeys, and an illusory man were to enter it. Son of the gods, what do you think? Do you think that anyone at all has entered it?

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, no one has."

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, the advance through the ten grounds of a bodhisattva should be seen in just the same way."

Then the son of the gods Susthitamati said this to Mañjuśrī, who had become a youth: "Mañjuśrī, if someone were to come to you in order to go forth, what would you say to that person about going forth? How would you make him go forth? How would you give him full ordination? How would you establish him in the aggregate of moral discipline? What instruction in the training would you confer?"

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, if someone comes to me in order to go forth, I say to him: 'Son of good family, if you do not give rise to the thought of going forth, then I will make you go forth.' Why is that? Son of the gods, whoever is made to go forth abides in the desire realm, or abides in the form realm, or abides in the formless realm, or abides in the five qualities of sense desire; whereas the son of good family who practices the nine states makes the Dharma directly manifest.

"Son of the gods, what are the nine? One who does not abide in anything at all does not focus on the mind. One who does not focus on the mind does not wish to go forth. One who does not wish to go forth does not give rise to the thought of going forth. One who does not give rise to the thought of going forth does not take birth. One who does not take birth is one in whom suffering is exhausted. One in whom suffering is exhausted is one in whom it is utterly exhausted. What is utterly exhausted is inexhaustible. What is inexhaustible does not become exhausted. What does not become exhausted is space. Son of the gods, that is what I say to that son of good family.

"Moreover, son of the gods, if someone comes to me in order to go forth, I say to him: 'Son of good family, do not give rise to the thought of going forth. Why? Because that mind is unborn; do not disturb it. Son of good family, if you

do not shave your hair, then you have gone forth well.'"

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, with what intention do you teach this?"

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, the Tathāgata teaches the Dharma because there is nothing to be cut and nothing to be divided."

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, what is it that is not cut, and what is it that is not divided?"

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, form is not cut and is not divided. Feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are not cut and are not divided. Son of the gods, whoever thinks, 'I am shaving my hair,' abides in grasping at 'I' and grasping at 'mine.' Those who engage in grasping at 'I' and grasping at 'mine' do not see sameness. For if there is apprehension of a self, there will be apprehension of hair; if there is apprehension of hair, there will be apprehension of a sentient being; and if there is apprehension of a sentient being, the notion of shaving will arise.

"Son of the gods, one who has no apprehension of a self has no apprehension of an other. One who has no apprehension of an other has no grasping at 'I.' One who has no grasping at 'I' abandons grasping at 'mine.' One who has abandoned grasping at 'mine' does not conceptualize. One who does not conceptualize does not change."

That which does not change is free of conceptual elaboration. That which is free of conceptual elaboration does not take up and does not discard. It does not make and does not destroy. It does not cut and does not divide. It does not join and does not part. It does not diminish. It does not abandon and does not decrease. It does not fill, does not gather, and does not scatter. It does not think in conceit. It does not speak, does not express, and does not fully express. That is abiding in reality.

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, what is it that is called reality?"

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, what is called reality is space. Space does not decrease or increase, nor does it arise or perish. Therefore that space is reality. Reality is emptiness. Reality is suchness. Reality is the realm of phenomena. Reality is the limit of reality. Whatever is reality has not come into being. Why is that? Because it has not come into being and will not come into being, it is what has not come into being.

"Furthermore, god's son, if someone comes to me in order to go forth, I say to him, 'Son of good family, if you do not hold saffron robes and do not wear

them, then I will let you go forth.'"

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, with what in mind do you teach this?"

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, the Tathāgata teaches the Dharma for the sake of non-grasping, not for the sake of grasping."

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, what is it that one does not grasp?"

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, one does not grasp form as permanent or as impermanent. One does not grasp feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness as permanent or as impermanent. One does not grasp the eye. One does not grasp form. One does not grasp the ear. One does not grasp sound. One does not grasp the nose. One does not grasp smell. One does not grasp the tongue. One does not grasp taste. One does not grasp the body. One does not grasp the tangible. One does not grasp the mind. One does not grasp mental phenomena. One does not grasp attachment. One does not grasp aversion. One does not grasp delusion. One does not grasp the inverted views. In short, god's son, one does not grasp, does not give up, does not abandon, and does not discard any phenomenon at all.

"God's son, I declare that whoever has the notion of grasping at saffron robes has the character of a view. God's son, one does not become pure or liberated by holding saffron robes. Why is that? Because, god's son, the awakening of the buddhas, the blessed ones, is free of impurity."

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, what is it that is called impurity?"

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, attachment is impurity. Aversion is impurity. Delusion is impurity. Cause is impurity. View is impurity. Name is impurity. Form is impurity. Perception is impurity. Fixation is impurity. Signs are impurity. Conceptual elaboration is impurity. God's son, not attending to those unwholesome phenomena is freedom from impurity. What is free of impurity is nothingness. What is nothingness is freedom from affliction. What is free of affliction is space."

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, when one speaks of 'nothing to be added, nothing to be added,' Mañjuśrī, what is it that is called 'nothing to be added'?"

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, 'nothing to be added, nothing to be added' means that not a single phenomenon is added to; that is what is called 'nothing to be added.' God's son, to those who add, the Tathāgata has said, 'There is nothing to be added.' That is what is called 'nothing to be added.'"

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, what is it that they add?"

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, they transgress equality, and having passed beyond equality, they abide wrongly in, and add to, a phenomenon that has not been found, is not found, and will not be found, that has not arisen, does not arise, and will not arise. That is to say, they conceive and add the notion of a self; they conceive and add the notions of a sentient being, a life, a person, one born of Manu, a son of Manu, permanence and annihilation; they conceive and add the notions of the aggregates, the elements, and the sense sources; they conceive and add the notions of the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha; they conceive and add the notions 'This one has moral discipline' and 'This one has broken moral discipline'; they conceive and add the notions of affliction and purification, of attainment, of result, and of what is to be directly realized; they conceive and add the notions of the result of stream-entry, the result of once-returning, the result of non-returning, arhatship, pratyekabuddhahood, and buddhahood; and they conceive and add the notions 'This is emptiness, signlessness, wishlessness, knowledge, liberation, and freedom from attachment.' God's son, childish ordinary people without learning conceive and add such additions. Those deluded people superimpose and fully conceptualize phenomena that are to be conceived. In order to turn back their inclination toward superimposition, the Tathāgata teaches that there is nothing to be added."

Then Susthitamati, the god's son, applauded the youthful Mañjuśrī, saying, "Excellent, Mañjuśrī, excellent! Mañjuśrī, you have explained this teaching on there being nothing to be added well. Excellent, excellent!"

The Blessed One also applauded the youthful Mañjuśrī, saying, "Excellent, Mañjuśrī, excellent! If one is to teach, one should teach in just this way."

Furthermore, the youthful Mañjuśrī spoke these words to Susthitamati, the god's son: "God's son, if anyone comes to me in order to go forth, I say to him, 'Son of good family, if you do not take full ordination, then you have gone forth.'"

The son of the gods asked, "Mañjuśrī, what do you have in mind when you teach this?"

Mañjuśrī replied, "Son of the gods, the Blessed One (the Buddha) has said that full ordination is of these two kinds. What are the two? Full ordination in evenness, and full ordination in unevenness.

"What, then, is full ordination in unevenness? It is falling into what is uneven. And what is uneven? Grasping at a self, grasping at a sentient being, grasping at a life principle, grasping at a person; permanence and annihilation; pride and wrong view; falling into attachment, aversion, and delusion; falling into the desire realm, the form realm, and the formless realm; excessive grasping, conceit, and falling into appropriation. In short, son of the gods, falling into all unwholesome phenomena, falling into the hands of evil companions, not knowing renunciation, and clinging to every kind of clinging: that, son of the gods, is full ordination in unevenness.

"What, then, is full ordination in evenness? It is descending into sameness. And what is sameness? The sameness of emptiness, the sameness of signlessness, and the sameness of wishlessness. Son of the gods, accomplishing the direct realization of these three doors of liberation correctly, just as they are, being without thought, without conceptuality, without imagining, and irreversible: that, son of the gods, is full ordination in evenness.

"Furthermore, son of the gods, what dispels attachment, dispels aversion, and dispels delusion; dispels craving, ignorance, the transitory collection, and the sixty-two kinds of views that arise from the root of the view of the transitory collection; dispels the inversions; and dispels the three kinds of misconduct, the eight wrongnesses, the nine grounds of malice, and the ten unwholesome courses of action: that is called genuine full ordination.

"Son of the gods, it is like this. For example, it is in dependence on the earth that all seeds sprout, and that all grasses, trees, medicinal plants, and forests grow; and when they have grown, they are said to be complete. In the same way, son of the gods, those who reach completion in this teaching are also called fully ordained.

"Son of the gods, it is like this. For example, the great earth is the support of all seeds, and perfect moral discipline should be regarded in the same way. Why is that? Because it is in dependence on moral discipline that the Dharma is clearly realized. Just as seeds and medicinal plants, when they have grown, are said to be complete, so too all the phenomena conducive to awakening, which rest on moral discipline and faith, arise and become complete. Son of the gods, realizing these three doors of liberation and completely cutting off all conceptual elaboration: that is the full ordination of all the śrāvakas of the buddhas, the blessed ones, of the past, the future, and the present.

"Son of the gods, whoever takes full ordination in this way takes genuine full ordination, not an uneven one.

"Furthermore, son of the gods, to one who has gone forth in this way and taken full ordination in this way, I give this instruction: 'Son of a noble family, if you do not take up the training, then you are one eager for the training.'"

The son of the gods asked, "Mañjuśrī, what do you have in mind when you teach this?"

Mañjuśrī replied, "Son of the gods, all phenomena are not taken up; therefore, son of the gods, whoever takes up moral discipline takes up the three realms. Son of the gods, what do you think? What do you suppose the training is?"

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, it is the vow of individual liberation (prātimokṣa)."

Mañjuśrī asked, "Son of the gods, and what is the vow of individual liberation?"

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, what is called a vow is restraint of body, restraint of speech, and restraint of mind. That is called the vow of individual liberation."

Mañjuśrī asked, "Son of the gods, what do you think? An action that has not been done, is not being done, and will not come to be done by body, speech, or mind: do you suppose it can be designated as blue, yellow, red, white, crimson, or crystal-colored?"

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, it cannot."

Mañjuśrī asked, "Son of the gods, then how should it be described?"

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, it should be described as without formation. It cannot be designated as bodily action, verbal action, or mental action."

Mañjuśrī asked, "Son of the gods, what do you think? Do you suppose that what is without formation can be taken up?"

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, it cannot."

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, it is for that reason, with that in mind, that I teach: 'Whoever does not take up the training is one eager for the training.'

"Son of the gods, what are called the training in higher moral discipline, the training in higher mind, and the training in higher wisdom should also be understood by that very principle. Because moral discipline is not

apprehended, it is called the training in higher moral discipline. Because mind is not apprehended, it is called the training in higher mind. Because wisdom is not apprehended, it is called the training in higher wisdom.

"Because the mind is without thought, without conceit, without conceptuality, and without arising, it is called the training in higher mind. Because moral discipline is without thought, without conceit, without conceptuality, and without arising, it is called the training in higher moral discipline. Because wisdom is without thought, without conceit, without conceptuality, and without arising, it is called the training in higher wisdom.

"Son of the gods, one who does not find the mind does not grow conceited about moral discipline. One who does not grow conceited about moral discipline does not apprehend meditative absorption. One who does not apprehend meditative absorption does not apprehend wisdom."

"Whoever does not apprehend wisdom has no doubts arise at all. Whoever has no doubts arise at all does not take up the training. Whoever does not take up the training is called one devoted to the training. Whoever is devoted to the training is a non-returner. Whoever is a non-returner is pure. Whoever is pure is free. Whoever is free is without defilement. Whoever is without defilement has rightly entered. Whoever has rightly entered is uncontrived. Whoever is uncontrived is space. Why is that? Because space is uncontrived.

"Son of the gods, whoever trains in this way does not train. Whoever does not train, trains. If one asks what he trains in: he trains in nothing at all. When he trains in nothing at all, he is called one who abides in the genuine training."

Further, the youthful Mañjuśrī said to the son of the gods Susthitamati: "Son of the gods, to one who has gone forth in this way and received full ordination in this way, I say: 'Son of good family, if you make full use of the gifts given in faith throughout the whole great trichiliocosm, and yet do not have to repay them, then you are pure in moral discipline.'"

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, with what in mind do you teach this?"

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, whoever takes and whoever takes pleasure must repay. Whoever apprehends must repay. Whoever is conceited must repay. Whoever conceptualizes must repay. Son of the gods, whoever does not take, does not take pleasure, does not apprehend, is not conceited, and does not conceptualize has nothing whatever to repay. Why is that? Because he is utterly pure.

"Therefore, son of the gods, ordinary beings must repay gifts given in faith, but arhats need not. Why is that? Ordinary beings take, take pleasure, apprehend, are conceited, and conceptualize. They think, 'I am the one who receives,' and they think, 'This one is the one who gives.' For that reason they are the ones who must repay. If one asks how they repay: they bring about birth among the destinies of existence, and there they repay. Son of the gods, arhats bring about no further body belonging to another existence, and so they have nothing whatever to repay. Even when they receive alms, they receive it with the three spheres completely pure.

"Son of the gods, what is this complete purity of the three spheres? No self that receives is apprehended, no giver who gives is apprehended, and no alms to be received is apprehended. Son of the gods, this is called the complete purity of the three spheres. Son of the gods, one who is pure in this way has nothing to repay. With this in mind I teach that whoever makes full use of the gifts given in faith throughout the whole great trichiliocosm and yet does not have to repay them is worthy of offerings in the world, and has gone forth well."

Further, the youthful Mañjuśrī said to the son of the gods Susthitamati: "Son of the gods, to one who has gone forth in this way and received full ordination in this way, I say: 'Son of good family, suppose you do not dwell in the wilderness, nor in a village, nor nearby, nor far away, nor off the road, nor alone, nor in the midst of many people, nor amid bustle, nor in solitude. You do not go on the alms round, nor go as a guest. You do not wear rag robes from the refuse heap, nor carry the despised bowl and robes. You do not live without a roof. You are not of few wishes, nor of many wishes. You are not content, nor discontent. You are not wholly secluded, nor wholly unsecluded. You do not stay at the foot of a tree, nor dwell in a house. You do not rely on discarded medicine, nor on ghee and honey. Son of good family, if you do not take up and engage in any such qualities of the ascetic practices, then you are endowed with ascetic practice.'

"Why is that? Son of the gods, those who think, 'I am a wearer of refuse rags; I am an alms-goer; I dwell at the foot of a tree; I am content with discarded medicine; I am of few wishes; I am content; I am a wilderness-dweller; I live without a roof; I am endowed with ascetic practice,' are caught in the agitations of the conceited. Son of the gods, for one who has rightly entered, who is free of all excessive agitation, those agitations do not arise. Why is that? Because he is without conceptual thought, he does not apprehend even

himself, so what need is there to speak of apprehending the qualities of the ascetic practices? For there is no basis for that.

"Therefore, son of the gods, I say that whoever takes up and engages in those qualities of the ascetic practices without being conceited and without conceptualizing them is endowed with ascetic practice. Why is that? Because, son of the gods, I say that a monk who purifies attachment, purifies aversion, purifies delusion, purifies the three realms, purifies the aggregates, purifies the elements, and purifies the six inner and the six outer sense sources, and who in no way takes them up, casts them away, cultivates them, removes them, or utterly eliminates them, one who purifies in this way is endowed with ascetic practice."

"Moreover, son of the gods, to one who has gone forth in this way and been fully ordained in this way, I say this: 'Son of noble family, suppose you do not realize the Four Truths. You do not cultivate the four applications of mindfulness, nor the four right abandonments, nor the four bases of miraculous power, nor the five faculties, nor the five powers, nor the seven limbs of awakening. You do not cultivate the noble eightfold path. You do not cultivate the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening, and you do not make them directly manifest. You do not cultivate the three doors of liberation, and you do not make them directly manifest. If that is so, then you are cultivating the factors conducive to awakening.'

"Why is that? Son of the gods, this is called realizing the characteristic of non-arising, because it cannot be cultivated and cannot be made directly manifest. And why is that? Because what does not arise cannot be made directly manifest.

"Son of the gods, as for what are called 'the applications of mindfulness': all phenomena are without mindfulness and without mental attention, and therefore they are called the applications of mindfulness.

"Son of the gods, a monk who does not abide in the desire realm, does not abide in the form realm, and does not abide in the formless realm is called a monk who abides in non-abiding and cultivates the applications of mindfulness. If one asks how he cultivates them: he does not cultivate anything at all, and he does not destroy anything. Because he cultivates in this way, he is called one who cultivates. The same applies to all thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening.

"Son of the gods, when a monk who is a yogin, through his practice of yoga, does not apprehend any phenomenon, at that time he forms no conceit. When he forms no conceit, at that time he does not cultivate. When he does not cultivate, at that time he does not make anything directly manifest. Why is that? Son of the gods, what are called the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening are mere names. That name, too, is unmoving and arisen from conditions. It has a single characteristic, that of having no characteristic, whether it is spoken or not spoken. For the full understanding of the name cannot be apprehended. The full understanding of the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening is the seeing of the truth."

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, people speak of 'a practitioner of yoga, a practitioner of yoga.' In what way is a monk a practitioner of yoga?"

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, when a practitioner of yoga joins all phenomena into a single mode by way of the mode of non-arising, he is therefore called a practitioner of yoga. When he does not practice anything at all, he is therefore called a practitioner of yoga. If one asks what he does not practice: because no phenomena exist, he does not practice in this world, he does not practice in the world beyond, and he does not practice in the three realms. Therefore he is called a practitioner of yoga. Son of the gods, when a practitioner of yoga neither joins nor separates any phenomenon at all, he is therefore called a practitioner of yoga."

Then many thousands of monks in that assembly thought, "The Blessed One, the Tathāgata, has said that one passes into nirvāṇa by realizing the three doors of liberation, and that one passes into nirvāṇa by making the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening directly manifest. If young Mañjuśrī has refuted this, how can this teaching of young Mañjuśrī be acceptable? Is this teaching of the Dharma not contradictory, and not in accord?" And thoughts of doubt arose in them.

Then young Mañjuśrī, knowing with his mind the thoughts in the minds of those monks, said to the elder Śāriputra, "Venerable Śāriputra, you are trusted by the Tathāgata, you are endowed with faith, and he has declared you foremost among those of great wisdom. Śāriputra, at the time when you made directly manifest the dharmas free from attachment, did the venerable one apprehend, make directly manifest, or cultivate the four truths? Did you apprehend, make directly manifest, or cultivate anything at all of the thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening and the three doors of

liberation?"

Śāriputra said, "Mañjuśrī, there was nothing of the kind. No phenomenon whatsoever that could be made directly manifest, cultivated, or realized can be apprehended. Why is that? Because all phenomena are ungraspable, unborn, and without cognition. Since they are empty, the empty does not make emptiness directly manifest."

When this teaching was explained, the minds of three thousand monks were liberated from the defilements, without clinging.

The fourth and final fascicle.

Then Susthitamati, the son of the gods, applauded young Mañjuśrī, saying "Excellent!" and continued, "Mañjuśrī, this has been taught by one who understands as soon as a thing is opened up, by one who has patience for the profound, by one who abides in emptiness. Excellent, excellent!"

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, I am not one who understands as soon as a thing is opened up. It is all childish ordinary beings who understand by opening things up. Why is that? Because they are the ones who open things up. If one asks what they open up: they open up the hells. They open up birth as animals. They open up the world of Yama. They open up the three realms. Thus, for those who open things up and who open everything up, the beginning of saṃsāra cannot be found. Son of the gods, the childish open up attachment everywhere. They open up aversion everywhere. They open up delusion everywhere. They open up views everywhere. They open up name and form everywhere. Son of the gods, the buddhas are not ones who understand by opening up, nor are the śrāvakas, nor the pratyekabuddhas, nor the bodhisattvas who have attained patience. Son of the gods, it is the childish who understand by opening up."

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, then are you one who understands when things are elaborated?"

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, that is not so."

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, must it then be interpreted?"

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, it is not that."

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, are you then one who is devoted to the words?"

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, it is so. I am one who is devoted to the words."

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, with what in mind do you teach this?"

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, a bodhisattva does not waver from even a single letter or a single word. He fully understands, exactly as they truly are, the meaning, the principle, the doorway and the path of that very letter and that very word. He understands, 'This is empty.' He understands, 'This is secluded.' He understands, 'This is without entity.' He understands, 'This is unborn.' And he understands in such a way that in no way does he cognize, in no way does he know, and in no way does he feel. For that reason he is called one who is devoted to the words."

Then the Blessed One (the Buddha) gave his approval to the youthful Mañjuśrī, saying, "Excellent! Mañjuśrī, this is how one who has attained dhāraṇī (the power of retention) teaches. Excellent, excellent!"

Mañjuśrī said, "Blessed One, I have not attained dhāraṇī. Why is that? Because, Blessed One, it is the childish who have attained dhāraṇī, while the buddhas and the bodhisattvas have not attained dhāraṇī. Why is that? Because, Blessed One, the childish are the ones who hold on. And what do they hold on to? They hold on to the grasping at a self. They hold on to the grasping at a sentient being, the grasping at a life, and the grasping at a person. They hold on to the grasping at annihilation and the grasping at permanence, and to attachment, aversion and delusion. They hold on to ignorance, to craving for existence, to the five aggregates, to the view of the transitory collection, to the eighteen elements, to the six inner sense sources and to the six outer sense sources. They hold on to thought, to conceptual thought, to imagining, and to the various kinds of views. Since that is how it is, Blessed One, it is the childish who have attained dhāraṇī. Because the logicians hold on to thought, conceptual thought, imagining and the various kinds of views, for that reason, Blessed One, the childish have attained dhāraṇī.

"Why is that? Because whatever things the childish hold on to, the buddhas do not hold on to, nor do the śrāvakas, nor do the pratyekabuddhas, nor do the bodhisattvas. For that reason the childish have attained dhāraṇī. Why is that? Because the childish hold on to what is not rightly held, while the buddhas do not, the śrāvakas do not, the pratyekabuddhas do not, and the bodhisattvas do not."

Then the god's son Susthitamati said to the youthful Mañjuśrī, "Mañjuśrī, if you have not attained dhāraṇī, are you then slow of understanding?"

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, it is so. I am slow of understanding. Why is that? Because, god's son, I possess an understanding so slow that even the buddhas, the śrāvakas, the pratyekabuddhas and the bodhisattvas do not know it. God's son, the ordinary childish people are not slow of understanding. Why is that? Because the ordinary childish people have an understanding that clings, while the wise possess slow understanding. If even stream-enterers are, for the time being, shown to have an understanding that clings, what need is there to mention other ordinary childish people? Therefore, god's son, I am slow of understanding and have not attained dhāraṇī. Why is that? Because I have not found anything at all to be held."

When this teaching was spoken, about five hundred monks in that assembly did not understand this discourse on the Dharma. Rejecting it and opposing it, they fell in those very bodies of theirs into the great hells.

Then the venerable Śāriputra said to the youthful Mañjuśrī, "Mañjuśrī, those five hundred or so monks did not understand this discourse on the Dharma, and having rejected and opposed it, they have fallen in those very bodies of theirs into the great hells. So do not teach such profound matters; teach with discernment!"

Mañjuśrī said, "Venerable Śāriputra, do not engage in conceptualizing! No phenomenon whatsoever that goes to hell can be found. Why is that? Because all phenomena are unborn.

"Moreover, venerable Śāriputra, as for your saying, 'Teach with discernment,' consider two cases, venerable Śāriputra. In the first, a son or daughter of good family who relies on the view of a self, or relies on the view of a sentient being, or on the view of a life, or on the view of a person, honors and serves, for as long as they live and with every requisite for comfort, tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas as numerous as the sands of the river Ganges, together with their saṅghas of monks. In the second, someone hears this profound Dharma, so hard to understand and so discordant with the whole world, hears that phenomena are empty, signless, wishless, peaceful, secluded, unborn, without sentient being, without life, without person, impermanent, suffering and selfless, and having heard it, rejects it and falls into the hells. Venerable Śāriputra, the son or daughter of good family who hears this profound Dharma, rejects it and falls into the hells will very quickly rise out of them and be liberated. But it is not so for the son or daughter of good family who relies on the view of a self and, without hearing this Dharma,

honors and serves tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas as numerous as the sands of the river Ganges."

Then the Blessed One (the Buddha) gave his approval to Mañjuśrī the Youthful, saying, "Excellent! Excellent, excellent, Mañjuśrī! It is just as you have said. Hearing this is like the appearance of a buddha. Hearing this is like the fruit of stream-entry. Hearing this is like the fruit of once-returning. Hearing this is like the fruit of non-returning. Hearing this is like arhatship itself. Why is that? Because for those who rely on the view of a self, and for those who hold to reference points, there is no attainment and no direct realization."

Then the Blessed One said this to the venerable Śāriputra: "Śāriputra, those monks will rise very quickly from those hells and pass into complete nirvāṇa. But the deluded people here who hold views with reference points, who are caught in doubt, and who make offerings to the Tathāgata, are not like that. Even so, Śāriputra, this will become a cause of their complete nirvāṇa, but they will not be quickly liberated. Why is that? Because they have not heard the profound teachings.

"Furthermore, Śāriputra, those sons or daughters of noble family who lend their ears and listen to this profound Dharma, yet do not understand it and reject it, and so go to hell, will be liberated very quickly. But others, who hold to reference points and are caught in doubt, are not like that."

Then the god's son Susthitamati said this to Mañjuśrī the Youthful: "Mañjuśrī, would you wish to live the holy life together with me?"

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, if you do not take up the holy life and do not practice the conduct of the holy life, then I wish to live the holy life together with you."

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, with what in mind do you say this?"

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, whoever takes something up practices, but whoever takes nothing up practices nothing at all. God's son, whoever apprehends the holy life practices it, but whoever does not apprehend it practices nothing at all."

The god's son said, "Then, Mañjuśrī, do you not live the holy life?"

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, that is so. I do not live the holy life. Why is that? Because I am neither holiness nor conduct, and therefore I do not live the holy life."

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, this has been taught by one endowed with unobstructed eloquence. Excellent, excellent!"

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, if I were endowed with unobstructed eloquence, then in that very way I would also be obstructed. Why is that? Because to whatever extent there is a 'mine,' and to whatever extent there is clinging, to that extent there is obstruction."

Further, Mañjuśrī the Youthful said this to the god's son Susthitamati: "God's son, if you deprive all sentient beings of life, yet take up no weapon, no sword, no clod of earth, and no club, then I wish to live the holy life together with you."

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, with what in mind do you say this?"

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, what do you understand that which is called 'sentient being, sentient being' to be?"

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, what is called 'sentient being, sentient being' is mere name and mere grasping perception."

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, that being so, the perception that grasps at a self should be killed. The perception that grasps at a sentient being should be killed. The perception that grasps at a life force should be killed. The perception that grasps at a person should be killed. The perception that grasps at a name should be killed."

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, with what should it be killed?"

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, it should be killed with the weapon of wisdom. And that weapon of wisdom should be held in such a way that there is no grasping whatsoever and no cutting, and in that way one should kill. God's son, by this line of reasoning you should understand that whoever kills the perception of a self and the perception of a sentient being has thereby killed all sentient beings."

Further, Mañjuśrī the Youthful said this to the god's son Susthitamati: "God's son, if you fully take up and engage in the ten paths of nonvirtuous action, and through the sameness of the entire dark side fully take up and engage in the entire bright side, then I wish to live the holy life together with you."

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, with what in mind do you say this?"

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, since whatever is the sameness of the dark side is, by that very fact, sameness, if you engage in sameness, then I wish to live the

holy life together with you. God's son, what do you think? What do you consider the sameness of the dark side to be?"

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, it is that there is nothing to be done and that nothing further is done."

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, what do you consider that which is called the bright side to be?"

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, the realm of phenomena, suchness, the limit of reality, and the three doors of liberation: that is the bright side."

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, can the realm of phenomena obscure?"

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, it cannot."

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, that is why, thinking of this, I said: 'If you fully take up and engage in the entire bright side through the sameness of the entire dark side, then I wish to live the holy life together with you.'"

Further, Mañjuśrī the Youthful said this to the god's son Susthitamati: "God's son, if you strike with a weapon the head of the first condemned one who has been led out for execution, then I wish to live the holy life together with you."

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, with what in mind do you say this?"

Mañjuśrī said, "God's son, what is it that is called 'the condemned, the condemned'? God's son, attachment is called the condemned. Aversion and delusion are called the condemned.

"Pride, anger, concealment, envy, deceit, guile, stinginess, clinging, signs, appropriation, perception, and feeling are called 'what is to be killed.' Son of the gods, these are said to be what is to be killed.

"Son of the gods, consider a yogin, a practitioner of yoga, who dispels, calms, and completely calms a mind of attachment that has arisen. Because it appears to him as empty, he does not turn to meditation on the unattractive. Instead he examines the arising and perishing of that very mind of attachment, asking: 'From what does this mind arise? Where does it cease? To what object does it become attached? By what does it become attached?' When he examines it in this way, he does not find attachment, nor does he find that to which one becomes attached or that by which one becomes attached. When he does not find them, he does not take them up. When he does not take them up, he does not cast them away. When he does not cast them away, he neither grasps nor rejects, and that is called nirvāṇa.

"The same should be applied to the mind of aversion, of delusion, of pride, anger, concealment, envy, deceit, guile, stinginess, clinging, signs, appropriation, perception, and feeling. Son of the gods, killing such a thing to be killed the very moment it arises is what is called 'striking with a weapon the head of the first one to be killed as soon as it comes forth.' That is why I said this, with this in mind."

Furthermore, Mañjuśrī, the Youthful One, said this to Susthitamati, son of the gods: "Son of the gods, if you do not please the Buddha, do not please the Dharma, and do not please the Saṅgha, then I would wish to live the holy life together with you."

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, with what in mind do you say that?"

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, what do you understand the one called 'Buddha' to be?"

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, it is suchness and the realm of phenomena."

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, what do you think? Do you think suchness and the realm of phenomena can be pleased?"

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, it cannot."

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, it is with this in mind that I said, 'If you do not please the Buddha, then I would wish to live the holy life together with you.' Son of the gods, what do you understand what is called 'Dharma' to be?"

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, what is called Dharma is freedom from attachment and the nature of reality."

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, what do you think? Do you think freedom from attachment and the nature of reality can be pleased?"

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, they cannot."

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, it is with this in mind that I said, 'If you do not please the Dharma, then I would wish to live the holy life together with you.' Son of the gods, what do you understand what is called 'Saṅgha' to be?"

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, the noble śrāvakas are distinguished by the unconditioned, and therefore the Saṅgha of the Blessed One's śrāvakas is unconditioned."

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, what do you think? Do you think the unconditioned can be pleased?"

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, it cannot."

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, it is with this in mind that I said, 'If you do not please the Saṅgha, then I would wish to live the holy life together with you.'

"Furthermore, son of the gods, whoever apprehends a buddha pleases the Buddha. Whoever apprehends a dharma pleases the Dharma. Whoever apprehends a saṅgha pleases the Saṅgha. Son of the gods, whoever does not apprehend a buddha, does not apprehend a dharma, and does not apprehend a saṅgha has certainly not pleased the Buddha, has not pleased the Dharma, and has not pleased the Saṅgha. Why is that? Because, since he does not apprehend them, he has not pleased them.

"Furthermore, son of the gods, those who are attached to the Buddha, attached to the Dharma, and attached to the Saṅgha have pleased the Buddha, pleased the Dharma, and pleased the Saṅgha. Those who do not apprehend the Buddha have no attachment to the Buddha, and so they have not pleased the Buddha. Those who have not apprehended the Dharma have no attachment to the Dharma, and so they have not pleased the Dharma. Those who have not apprehended the Saṅgha have no attachment to the Saṅgha, and so they have not pleased the Saṅgha.

"Son of the gods, what is called 'not having pleased' is the state free from attachment. It is the state free from fetters. It is the state of dismantling. It is the state free from mind. It is the state that has not arisen. It is the state of certainty. It is the state in which mentation has not been made to arise, and for that reason it is called 'not having pleased.' Son of the gods, therefore it is with this in mind that I said, 'If you do not please the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha, then I would wish to live the holy life together with you.'"

Then Susthitamati, son of the gods, said this to Mañjuśrī, the Youthful One: "Mañjuśrī, how wonderful it is, the extent to which you teach these profound matters! We shall be grateful to you for what you have done."

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, do not be grateful for what has been done."

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, then should I be ungrateful for what has been done?"

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, just so. Son of the gods, be ungrateful for what has been done, and do not be grateful for what has been done."

The son of the gods said, "Mañjuśrī, are you, then, ungrateful for what has been done?"

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, just so. I am ungrateful for what has been done, not grateful for what has been done."

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, with what in mind do you teach this?"

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, fools do one thing and another in all sorts of ways, and so fools are the makers of this and that. Because they make all sorts of views, they are called grateful, those who make a return for what was done. Son of the gods, the sons of good family who have rightly entered the path do nothing at all, neither what should be done nor what should not be done. Since they do nothing, they are called ungrateful, those who make no return for what was done. The buddhas, the blessed ones, have declared: 'All phenomena are without action, without agent, without any further doing. They do not pass beyond sameness, nor do they take up anything else, and since they do nothing else, they are sameness.' Because they have declared this, it is called making no return for what was done."

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, do you teach this while abiding in patience, or in the nature of reality, or in what?"

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, it is neither in patience nor in the nature of reality."

The god's son said, "Then, Mañjuśrī, in what do you abide as you teach this?"

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, in that in which the body of an illusory person abides."

The god's son said, "Mañjuśrī, in what does the body of an illusory person abide?"

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, the body of an illusory person abides in that in which suchness abides. Furthermore, son of the gods, as for your asking whether I teach this while abiding in patience, or in the nature of reality, or in what: son of the gods, what is called patience is a mere name, and one cannot abide in a name. The nature of reality, too, is unchanging and free of conceptual thought, so there is no abiding in it either. Son of the gods, the Tathāgata dwells and teaches in that very thing in which all sentient beings abide and teach. Why is that? The Tathāgata dwells in suchness and teaches, and all sentient beings, too, do not stir from suchness, because the suchness

of all sentient beings and the suchness of the Tathāgata are one suchness, without duality."

Then the god's son Susthitamati said this to the youthful Mañjuśrī: "Mañjuśrī, we speak of śramaṇas and brahmins. By what is one called a śramaṇa and a brahmin?"

Mañjuśrī said, "Son of the gods, one who is neither a śramaṇa nor a brahmin is called a śramaṇa and a brahmin. Why is that? Son of the gods, I say that one who is not attached to the desire realm, nor attached to the form and formless realms, is a śramaṇa. Son of the gods, I say that one who does not leak through the eye, does not leak through the ear, does not leak through the nose, does not leak through the tongue, does not leak through the body, and does not leak through the mind is a śramaṇa. Son of the gods, I say that one who has no abiding and no designation of abiding, no settled abiding and no designation of settled abiding, is a śramaṇa. And son of the gods, I say that one who comes from nowhere, goes nowhere, and is without wound and free of wounds is a brahmin. That is the explanation of the statement, 'One who is neither a śramaṇa nor a brahmin is called a śramaṇa and a brahmin.'"

Now in that very assembly there had gathered five bodhisattvas who had cultivated the four meditative concentrations and attained the five superknowledges. Since they had not yet attained patience, they would abide and enter into absorption, and abide and arise from it. Those bodhisattvas remembered former lives in which they had killed their fathers, killed their mothers, and killed arhats. Because a remainder of the karma whose maturation was due them still remained, their minds were tormented, and through that torment they could not accept the profound teachings. They relied on a self and engaged only in conceptual thought. Because they had not attained patience with regard to the Dharma, they were unable to subdue that obsession.

Then the Blessed One, for the sake of taming those five bodhisattvas, directed the mind of the youthful Mañjuśrī. The youthful Mañjuśrī then rose from his seat, draped his upper robe over one shoulder, took up a sword in his right hand, sharpened it well, and rushed toward the Blessed One.

Then the Blessed One said this to the youthful Mañjuśrī: "Mañjuśrī, I am already killed, well and truly killed, so go ahead! Why is that? Mañjuśrī, whenever people give rise to the thought 'I kill,' at that very moment they have long since been killed."

Then those five bodhisattvas thought, "All phenomena are like illusions. In this there is no self, no sentient being, no life force, no person, no one born of Manu, no son of Manu at all. In this there is no father, no mother, no Buddha, no Dharma, no Saṅgha. In this there is no one at all who commits a deed of immediate retribution. Why is that? This youthful Mañjuśrī is learned, wise and intelligent. He is praised and lauded by all the buddhas, he accepts the profound, he has served many hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of buddhas, he has rendered great service to the victors of the past, he is skilled in the knowledge that discerns all phenomena, he teaches the Dharma just as it is, he speaks truly, and he is full of reverence for the Tathāgata. Yet he took up a sharp weapon and ran toward the Tathāgata, and the Tathāgata in turn said, 'Mañjuśrī, I am already killed, well and truly killed, so go ahead!' If there were established in this some permanently abiding thing called Buddha, called Dharma, called Saṅgha, called father, called mother, or called arhat, then for one who commits a deed of immediate retribution there would be no deliverance at all. But since those things are nonexistent, false, wrongly grasped, empty and like illusions, there is, therefore, no doer at all here who would act, nor anyone toward whom an act would be done."

Because those five bodhisattvas understood in this way, they attained acceptance of the nonarising of phenomena. Through that very joy and supreme joy they rose into the sky to the height of seven palm trees, and once they had risen they praised the Blessed One (the Buddha) with these verses:

All phenomena are like illusions,
Wholly produced by imagination.
Nothing in them is established;
All these phenomena are empty.
The deluded, who perceive a self,
Engage in mistaken imagining.
We remember, too, the unbearable
Evil deeds we did in former times.
In our previous lives
We killed fathers, mothers, and those worthy of offerings,
And committed the most unbearable evil
Of killing monks who were arhats.
Through the ripening of those evil deeds
We experienced painful feelings,
And the remorse that arose in us

Was purified by hearing the Dharma.
The Greatly Renowned One, who draws out the thorn,
Has dispelled our remorse,
And so we have come to realize the dharmadhātu,
In which there are no afflictions.
The Buddha is skilled in means;
The Sage possesses knowledge of means.
By those means he dispels
The remorse of all sentient beings.
Since phenomena are empty of intrinsic nature,
Here neither Buddha nor Dharma
Nor Saṅgha is apprehended;
Here there is no father, no mother, no arhat.
Here there is no one to be killed,
Nor is there any killing at all.
Sameness occurs just as it is;
That is the characteristic of phenomena.
Mañjughoṣa, of great wisdom,
Who has gone beyond in all phenomena,
Took up a sharp sword
And rushed to where the Buddha sat.
As the Buddha is, so is the sword;
The two of them have a single characteristic.
They are unborn, and there is no arising;
Here there is no killing at all.

While this Dharma discourse of the taking up of the sword was being taught, buddhafields of the ten directions as numerous as the grains of sand in the river Ganges shook in six ways, and a great earthquake took place in the world.

Then, in those buddhafields in the world systems of the ten directions, the buddhas, the blessed ones, who were dwelling, living, and abiding there were asked by their own attendants: "Blessed One, by whose power has this great earthquake taken place in the world?"

Those buddhas, the blessed ones, replied: "Sons of noble family, there is a world system called the Sahā world. There the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha called Śākyamuni teaches the Dharma. In that

Sahā world dwells a bodhisattva called the youthful Mañjuśrī, who is irreversible from unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. In order to tame other bodhisattvas, he took up the sharp weapon of the sword of wisdom and rushed toward where the Blessed One, the Tathāgata Śākyamuni, was."

Then those buddhas, the blessed ones, took the sword of wisdom as their theme and taught the Dharma in such a way that countless sentient beings had their eyes purified, had their minds liberated, gave rise to acceptance, and set out for awakening.

Then the Blessed One exercised his blessing so that those beginners seated in that assembly who had few roots of virtue and much conceptual thought would neither see the sword nor hear that teaching of the Dharma.

Then the Elder Śāriputra said to the youthful Mañjuśrī, "Mañjuśrī, you have committed a terrible violent deed in order to kill the Teacher. Where will it ripen for you?"

Mañjuśrī said, "Venerable Śāriputra, it is so. It is just as you have said. I have done such a terrible deed, yet I do not know the place where it will ripen. Even so, venerable Śāriputra, wherever the deed of an illusory person ripens, there mine too will ripen. And why is that? Because, venerable Śāriputra, an illusory person neither conceives nor conceptualizes, and all phenomena too neither conceive nor conceptualize. Venerable Śāriputra, I shall therefore question the venerable one himself. Answer according to what you accept. Venerable one, can a sword be apprehended?"

Śāriputra said, "Mañjuśrī, it cannot."

Mañjuśrī said, "Venerable one, can a deed be apprehended?"

Śāriputra said, "Mañjuśrī, it cannot."

Mañjuśrī said, "Venerable one, can a ripening be apprehended?"

Śāriputra said, "Mañjuśrī, it cannot."

Mañjuśrī said, "Venerable Śāriputra, if there is no sword, no deed, and no ripening, then where will that deed ripen?"

Śāriputra said, "Mañjuśrī, according to what you have shown with that intention, that deed will not ripen anywhere at all. And why is that? Because all phenomena are without deeds and without ripening."

Then the bodhisattvas who had gathered from the world systems of the ten directions made this request to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please, out of

compassion, encourage the youthful Mañjuśrī so that he will come to our buddhafields and teach the Dharma in those buddhafields."

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī said to those bodhisattvas, "Sons of noble family, look now at your own buddhafields."

Then those bodhisattvas looked at their own buddhafields throughout the ten directions. As they looked, they heard the pleasing voice of the youthful Mañjuśrī coming from those buddhafields of their own throughout the ten directions. They saw the youthful Mañjuśrī sitting before those buddhas, the blessed ones, teaching the Dharma to the god's son Susthitamati as he asked about this very Dharma discourse, and they saw the same multitude of bodhisattvas and the same multitude of gods' sons gathered there. Seeing this, they thought, "How wondrous it is that the youthful Mañjuśrī, without moving from this buddhafield, shows his presence in this way everywhere. How wondrous!" And they were filled with wonder.

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī spoke these words to those bodhisattvas: "Sons of noble family, consider this example. A magician who has trained thoroughly in illusion does not even stir from his seat, yet he displays forms of every kind. In the same way, a bodhisattva who has trained well in the Perfection of Wisdom produces, among phenomena that are like illusions, as many emanations as there are buddha fields in which he wishes to show his face. Why is that? Because he knows these phenomena to be like illusions."

Then the Blessed One said to the youthful Mañjuśrī: "Mañjuśrī, hearing this Dharma discourse is like the appearance of a buddha. Hearing this Dharma discourse is like the fruit of stream-entry. Hearing this Dharma discourse is like the fruit of once-returning. Hearing this Dharma discourse is like the fruit of non-returning. Hearing this Dharma discourse is like arhatship. Mañjuśrī, to have devotion and faith in this Dharma discourse and to sit at the seat of awakening are equal."

Mañjuśrī replied: "Blessed One, so it is. They are equal in just the way that emptiness is. They are equal in just the way that signlessness is. They are equal in just the way that wishlessness is. They are equal in just the way that suchness is. They are equal in just the way that the dharma realm is. They are equal in just the way that the true limit is. They are equal in just the way that sameness is. They are equal in just the way that liberation is. They are equal in just the way that solitude is."

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, may the Tathāgata bless this Dharma discourse so that in the future, when the final five hundred years have come, it will by all means be practiced and will reach the ears of sons and daughters of noble family."

At that moment, throughout this great trichiliocosm, all the musical instruments of gods and humans, however many there were, sounded forth without being played. From all the trees, too, flowers of many kinds blossomed fully and fell. From the ponds, too, many lotuses sprang up. This great trichiliocosm shook in six ways and was pervaded by a great light, so that even the sun and the moon could no longer be seen. Many hundreds of thousands of millions of gods, delighted, joyful, and glad, stationed themselves in the sky above and let fall showers of flowers, and they also let fall showers of powders, incense, garlands, and ointments. They played cymbals and sang many divine songs, and all of them, joining their palms and bowing, said in unison these words:

"Alala! The Dharma taught by the youthful Mañjuśrī! Alala, the Dharma! Alala, the Dharma! We see the wheel of Dharma turned a second time in the world! Those beings who hear this Dharma discourse and, having heard it, have devotion to it, are not endowed with meager roots of virtue. Those who hear this Dharma discourse and are not frightened have rendered special service to the victors of the past and have patience for the profound."

Then the youthful Mañjuśrī said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, since these omens have occurred for the blessing of this Dharma discourse, it will be practiced in future times."

The Blessed One said: "Mañjuśrī, so it is. These omens have occurred for the blessing of this Dharma discourse."

Mañjuśrī said, "Blessed One (the Buddha), so that this Dharma discourse may endure for a long time, may the Blessed One please make a blessing of truth."

The Blessed One said, "Mañjuśrī, by the truth and the words of truth through which one is liberated by relying on the three doors of liberation, by that truth and those words of truth, may this Dharma discourse circulate in the future, in the last five hundred years."

Mañjuśrī said, "Blessed One, by the truth and the words of truth according to which there is no self, no sentient being, no life force, no person, no one born of Manu, no son of Manu, no affliction and no purification, by that truth and

those words of truth, may this Dharma discourse circulate in the future, in the last five hundred years.

"Blessed One, by the truth and the words of truth according to which there is no attachment, no aversion, no delusion; no name, no form, no cause, no view; no existence, no seeking after existence; no body, no designation as a body; no mind, no designation as a mind; no mindfulness, no acts of recollection, no applications of mindfulness, no placing, no close placing; no form, no feeling, no perception, no formations, no consciousness; no eye and no form, no ear and no sound, no nose and no smell, no tongue and no taste, no body and no touch, no mind and no phenomena; no desire realm, no form realm, no formless realm; and in this there is no permanence and no annihilation, by that truth and those words of truth, may this Dharma discourse circulate in the future, in the last five hundred years.

"Blessed One, by the truth and the words of truth according to which there is no stream-enterer and no fruit of stream-entry, no once-returner and no fruit of once-returning, no non-returner and no fruit of non-returning, no arhat and no qualities of an arhat, no pratyekabuddha and no qualities of a pratyekabuddha, no Tathāgata and no qualities of a Tathāgata; no powers, no fearlessnesses, no wisdom, no consciousness; no emptiness, no signlessness, no wishlessness; no freedom from attachment, no intrinsic nature, no attainment, no direct realization, no full comprehension, no knowledge, no liberation; no shore, no far shore, no near shore, no freedom; no name and no designation by name, by that truth and those words of truth, may this Dharma discourse circulate in the future, in the last five hundred years.

"Blessed One, by the truth and the words of truth according to which this teaching of the Dharma has bound no one and freed no one, and binds no one and frees no one, by that truth and those words of truth, may this Dharma discourse circulate in the future, in the last five hundred years.

"Blessed One, by the truth and the words of truth according to which the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas of the past freed no sentient being and led none to complete nirvāṇa; they found no sentient being and destroyed none; they produced no phenomenon, stopped none, destroyed none and set none in motion; and the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas of the future will free no sentient being and will lead none to complete nirvāṇa; they will find no sentient being and will destroy none; they will produce no phenomenon, will stop none, will destroy none and will

set none in motion; and the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas who have now appeared free no sentient being and lead none to complete nirvāṇa; they find no sentient being and destroy none; they produce no phenomenon, stop none, destroy none and set none in motion, by that truth and those words of truth, may this Dharma discourse circulate in the future, in the last five hundred years.

"Blessed One, by the truth and the words of truth according to which in this teaching of the Dharma nothing at all has been spoken, uttered, explained, taught, examined, proclaimed, related, mentioned or recited, and in this teaching of the Dharma not even a single letter has been uttered; according to which this teaching of the Dharma has been heard by no one, no one will hear it, and no one will be liberated, by that truth and those words of truth, may this Dharma discourse circulate in Jambudvīpa in the future, in the last five hundred years.

"Blessed One, by the truth and the words of truth according to which in this there is no moral discipline and no fruit of moral discipline, no meditative absorption and no ground of meditative absorption, no wisdom and no faculty of wisdom, no liberation and no wisdom of liberation, by that truth and those words of truth, may this Dharma discourse circulate in Jambudvīpa in the future, in the last five hundred years.

"Blessed One, by the truth and the words of truth according to which a bodhisattva does not give gifts, does not guard moral discipline, does not accomplish patience, does not undertake diligence, does not cultivate the meditative concentrations, does not practice wisdom, does not strive for awakening, does not enter into what is authentic, does not attain awakening, does not attain the powers,

does not attain the fearlessnesses, does not attain the faculties, does not attain the analytical knowledges, does not turn the wheel of Dharma, does not liberate sentient beings, and does not speak. By this truth and by these true words, may this Dharma discourse be practiced in Jambudvīpa in the final five hundred years of the future!

Then at that moment this great trichiliocosm, this world system of a thousand million worlds, shook in six ways.

Then the bodhisattva Maitreya said this to the Blessed One (the Buddha): "Blessed One, what is the cause and what is the condition for this great quaking that has taken place in the world?"

When he had said this, the Blessed One spoke these words to the bodhisattva Maitreya: "Maitreya, will these beings who are inclined toward the inferior not fail to take this in? It is better to let it be."

When he had said this, the bodhisattva Maitreya said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, for the benefit of many people, for the happiness of many people, and for the sake of gods and humans, please explain it."

The Blessed One said, "Maitreya, this very Dharma discourse was taught in this very place by seventy-four hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas of buddhas, and in every case it was requested by the youthful Mañjuśrī and by the divine son Susthitamati."

Maitreya said, "Blessed One, how long has it been since the youthful Mañjuśrī and the divine son Susthitamati heard this Dharma discourse?"

The Blessed One said, "Maitreya, a hundred thousand incalculable eons ago, these sons of good family heard this Dharma discourse from the Tathāgata called Heap of Virtues of the Lion's Prowess, Exalted with Flowers on Every Side. When this Dharma discourse was taught, as many sentient beings as there are grains of sand in the river Ganges gave rise to the mind set on unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. Twice that number attained the patience of nonregression. And for twice that number again, the Dharma eye regarding phenomena became pure, free of dust and stainless."

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, those monks, the youthful Mañjuśrī, the divine son Susthitamati, all the bodhisattvas who had gathered there, those divine sons, the venerable Śāriputra, the elder Mahākāśyapa, and the world with its gods, humans, asuras and gandharvas rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

This completes the thirty-sixth chapter, "The Questions of the Divine Son Susthitamati," from the noble Dharma discourse of the Great Heap of Jewels in a hundred thousand chapters.

It was proofread by the monk Lu'i Gyaltsen.

Translator's Notes

• The heading "lung bstan pa" attached to the title is taken in its sense of an explanation given in answer to a request, since the work consists of answers to questions; it could also be read as "prophecy." Many bodhisattva names in the list could not be confidently matched to attested Sanskrit forms and are translated by meaning (for example Utterly Unshakable, Armor That Transforms Women, Supreme King of Hosts). The repeated phrase describing the arhats is

taken as "renowned"; it could alternatively mean "endowed with the superknowledges." "Free of afflictions" is read as describing Mañjuśrī's state rather than as part of the samādhi's name; the Tibetan permits either.

• "Profound acceptance" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□, the bodhisattva's acceptance of the profound nature of phenomena. The name of the absorption is translated by meaning. The buddhas, speaking in a single unified voice, use the first person singular at the end ("I shall explain"), as the Tibetan does.

• The name of the meditative absorption is translated by its meaning ("Stainless Array of Universal Illumination") since its Sanskrit form cannot be confidently reconstructed. The phrases rendered "serves as a father" and "serves as a mother" translate an idiom meaning literally "opens the place of father / mother," that is, takes on that role toward the bodhisattvas.

• The flower called "kyanar" is given in phonetics because it could not be confidently identified with a Sanskrit name. The three "moon-colored" flowers are translated literally from the Tibetan, as their Sanskrit names are uncertain. The verse continues into the next piece.

• The number words khrag khrig and dkrigs are large Indian numerical units whose exact values vary between systems; they are rendered here as "trillion" and "quadrillion". In the last verse, "should run dry" interprets the unclear phrase "rgya mtsho bas gyur". In the sixth verse the final word "khum" is unclear; it is taken as a request to remove doubts, in line with the refrain. The pigeon verse alludes to the well-known story of King Śibi.

• The name of the absorption, literally "the complete destruction (or disintegration) of all bodies," is rendered "the destruction of all bodies" throughout. Mahākāśyapa's remark beginning "Were I to think of setting all sentient beings even in the qualities of arhatship" is elliptical in the Tibetan; the sense appears to be that he could scarcely conceive of setting beings even in arhatship, let alone buddhahood. "Until the youthful Mañjuśrī has passed by" renders an unexplained phrase whose reference depends on the surrounding narrative.

• Large numbers: "koṭis of niyutas" renders the Tibetan bye ba khrag khrig, a standard pair of Indian high numerals. The "billion realms" of the Four Great Kings renders ther 'bum, the count of such realms in a great trichiliocosm. In the third verse, the line literally reads "where feelings come to be experienced," that is, where the results of indulgence are felt.

• The name □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ could not be identified with confidence; it is translated by meaning as "Rich in Modesty" (perhaps Sanskrit Hrīdhana or similar). The final sentences say only that they "touched" the feet; touching with the head, the standard gesture of reverence, is understood.

• The dialogue turns on the verb meaning both "to turn back" and, negated, "irreversible" (the bodhisattva's non-regression). Susthitamati praises teaching "for the sake of irreversibility"; Mañjuśrī replies paradoxically that it is the bodhisattva who "turns back" (from afflictions, views and perceptions) who awakens. "Perishable aggregate" renders the term for satkāya, the basis of the view of a real personal self.

• The passage plays throughout on ldog pa, "to turn away, turn back": the bodhisattva who turns away from conceptualizing is one who "does not turn back," that is, an irreversible bodhisattva. The sentence on suchness ("it is simply that one fully understands as nonexistent the perception, 'It is something that had not come about before'") is syntactically compressed, and the rendering is interpretive. The phrase rendered "all the lotuses that ranged through this great trichiliocosm" refers to lotuses not otherwise introduced in this piece, and its exact sense is uncertain.

• The word rendered "escorts" in the list of gifts is uncertain; it may refer to a small troop or retinue, or to some item of furnishing. "The excellent medicine of what is discarded" refers to the fourth of the ascetic supports, medicine made from discarded or fermented substances, alongside rag robes, alms and dwelling at the foot of a tree.

• The text reads □□□□□□□□□□□, "turning hands," where the parallel phrase just before this piece has □□□□□□□□□□, "hands on staffs"; translated as "leaning on staffs," taking □□□□ as a slip for □□□. □□□□□□□□ is rendered "a billion," following the common Tibetan numeral system; the exact value intended may differ. The phrase □□□□□□□, literally "not manifest," is taken to mean that the proclamation of other buddhas' names has no evident effect on the māras.
• The passage announces twenty aspects, but the list as given has twenty-one items; translated as it stands. The Sanskrit form Mandāravagandha is reconstructed from the Tibetan "Fragrance of the Mandārava Flower." The name of the later tathāgata could not be confidently restored to Sanskrit and is translated into English. "Maṇḍalas of Māra" may also be understood as "all the circles" or "spheres" of Māra's power.
• The phrase rendered "scope for your work of Māra, the making of obstacles" could also be read as "an object for the obstructing activity of Māra"; the sense, that Māra finds an opening wherever there is reification, is the same.
• Several of the bodhisattva names could not be identified with confidence and are translated by meaning: "Weapon of Māra," "Pacifier of Evil," "Guardian of Victory," and "Renowned Dharma King." Dharmodgata, Dharmamati, Sūrya, Mañjughoṣa and Śāntarakṣita are the usual Sanskrit equivalents of their Tibetan names. Mañjughoṣa here is a separate bodhisattva in the list, distinct from Mañjuśrī. The text plays on "understand" as the sense of bodhi in "bodhisattva." In "produced by discursive thought," the text spells the word as "understanding" in this one place. It is read here as "discursive thought," in parallel with the item before it.
• The Blessed One's answer, literally "generates perception and mental attention from all of the three realms," is ambiguous; the paradoxical exchange that follows suggests the sense given, but "from" could also imply turning perception away from the three realms. The edition's volume label marking the start of a new Ratnakūṭa volume has been omitted as a physical marker; the fascicle title has been kept. In the verse on the inversions, the Tibetan word for "wrong" is read as the common spelling of that word.
• The passage plays on two related verbs: "to generate" or "produce" (applied paradoxically to attachment, views and so on) and "arising" (as in the arising of the mind of awakening). "That limit" renders a word usually meaning "extreme"; here it likely refers to the limit of reality (bhūtakoṭi), listed beside dharmadhātu and sameness. "The perishing collection" is the transitory aggregates, the object of the view of a real self (satkāyadṛṣṭi).
• "Forbearance regarding nonarising phenomena" renders the technical term anutpattikadharmakṣānti, often also translated "acceptance of the nonarising of phenomena." The final item in Mañjuśrī's list of what ordinary beings do, a word meaning "to bow down," is taken as self-abasement, the counterpart of being puffed up with pride just before it.
• In the list of ways of accepting the teaching, the text reads "destroys" ('jig par byed), which makes no sense among "accepts, is devoted to, has faith in"; I have read the similar-looking 'jug par byed, "enters into". The pair rendered "hollow and vain" reads gsog dang gso ba; I take gso ba as the familiar gsob pa, "vain", of the stock pair gsog gsob. The opening speech is the Buddha addressing Mañjuśrī, as Mañjuśrī's reply "Blessed One" shows. The pun on forbearance as "not being wounded" (rmas pa) is kept literally.
• The Tibetan □ means both "ground" (bhūmi) and "storey," so the illusory ten-storeyed building is a deliberate play on the ten bodhisattva grounds. Likewise "nothing to be cut" plays on the cutting of hair at ordination.
• The recurring term "nothing to be added" (literally "absence of anything to be made extra or superfluous") is rendered consistently with the verb "add," in the sense of adding conceptual overlays to what is. Its exact Sanskrit equivalent is uncertain. "One born of Manu" and "son of Manu" render the standard terms for manuja and mānava in the classic list of wrong notions of a self.

• The passage plays on full ordination (upasaṃpadā) and "completion" (the Tibetan rdzogs pa), and on evenness or sameness versus unevenness; the renderings "in evenness" and "in unevenness" try to keep that play. "Eager for the training" renders a phrase meaning literally "one who desires the training." The Tibetan de skud is read as the evident de skad, "thus."
• The verb that recurs in the section on gifts given in faith carries a double sense, "to purify" and "to repay or work off a debt." There it is rendered "repay," because the text explains it as working off the gift through rebirth. In the final section the same verb is rendered "purify," which plays on "ascetic practices," a term built on the same root. "Discarded medicine" refers to the ascetic's medicine of fermented urine or discarded substances.
• "One who understands as soon as a thing is opened up" renders a technical term for a disciple of the quickest type (Skt. udghaṭitajña), followed in this and the next passage by the other classical types: "one who understands upon elaboration" (vipañcitajña), "one who must be led," and "one for whom the words are paramount." Mañjuśrī puns on the verb "to open up, to separate, to differentiate": the childish "open up" the hells and the rest, that is, they create them through conceptual differentiation. A similar wordplay runs through the passage on the "practitioner of yoga," where yoga is taken as "joining."
• The exchange plays on the word dhāraṇī, from the root meaning "to hold": Mañjuśrī ironically says that it is the childish who "hold," since they hold on to grasping, while buddhas and bodhisattvas hold nothing. Likewise "slow of understanding" is used ironically for a realization that does not cling. "Must it be interpreted" renders a verb meaning "to lead or draw out," which may allude to meaning requiring interpretation (neyārtha).
• The wordplay in "I am neither holiness nor conduct" splits the compound for the holy life (brahmacarya) into its two parts, "holy" (brahma) and "conduct" (carya). In the final exchange, the Tibetan word rendered "the condemned" means literally "one to be killed"; Mañjuśrī reinterprets it as the afflictions to be slain.
• "Live the holy life together with you" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ (Skt. sabrahmacārin, a fellow practitioner of the holy life); it does not refer to the god Brahmā. The phrase rendered "the state in which mentation has not been made to arise" (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□) is somewhat uncertain; it may play on the sense "not made glad," mirroring "not having pleased." "Grateful" and "ungrateful" render □□□□□□□□□□ and □□□□□□□□□□□□ (kṛtajña, akṛtajña, "acknowledging" or "not acknowledging what has been done"); the paradox is explained in the next section.
• The exchange plays on the Tibetan expression for "grateful" and "ungrateful," literally "one who makes a return for what was done" and "one who does not." Mañjuśrī's point turns on the idea of making or fabricating, so both senses are kept together. The Buddha's words to Mañjuśrī, "go ahead," render an imperative meaning "let go" or "release." The terms rendered "born of Manu" and "son of Manu" are the standard Tibetan renderings of manuja and mānava, two items in the stock list of notions of a self. "Directed the mind" renders the Buddha's inspiring or prompting Mañjuśrī to act.
• The verse line rendered "Nor is there any killing at all" reads literally as a double negative ("it is not that there is no killing at all"). That would contradict the context, so it has been taken as emphatic negation. In the attendants' question, the word preceding "great earthquake" is obscure and has been read simply as part of "this great earthquake."
• The exclamation rendered "Alala!" is an expression of wonder and delight, kept as an interjection rather than translated. The phrase rendered "they are equal in just the way that emptiness is" literally reads "that is alike just as emptiness is," and makes the point that devotion to the teaching and sitting at the seat of awakening are equal in the same way that emptiness and the other ultimate categories are without distinction.
• The terms rendered "no one born of Manu" and "no son of Manu" correspond to the standard

pair manuja and mānava in lists denying a self. "Enter into what is authentic" most likely refers to entering the certainty of the right path (samyaktvaniyāma). The piece ends mid-sentence; the list continues in the next piece.
• The name of the past tathāgata is translated from its Tibetan meaning, as a Sanskrit form could not be confidently reconstructed. The Buddha's reply to Maitreya's first question, rendered "will these beings who are inclined toward the inferior not fail to take this in? It is better to let it be," is somewhat terse in the Tibetan. It expresses hesitation to explain, for fear that beings of lesser aspiration could not grasp the teaching. Maitreya then renews his request.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.